BOOK OF USEFUL SHELTERING INFORMATION

USEFUL SHELTERING INFORMATION (8/3/26)

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ANIMALS IN SHELTERS

CATS:

- Cats need very large crates (because they're in there, 24/7)
- Litter box on one end, "bed" in the middle and food and water at the other end. Litter should never be near the food and water.
- Crates must be completely covered with blankets to reduce stress and odors.
- Litter boxes should be replaced every other day.

DOGS:

- Dogs should be in crates that are large enough for the dog to sit, stand and turn around. They don't need a crate any larger because they get exercise at least twice a day.
- Dogs must be walked a <u>minimum</u> of twice a day.
- Designate an "Exit" door and an "Entrance" door. This is to ensure that no two dogs are ever nose to nose.
- Dog's crates should also be covered in blankets to reduce stress.

REPTILES:

- Most reptiles will need heat lamps because they can't regulate their body temperature.
- Reptiles will need to be in aquarium style enclosures with GOOD latches.

BIRDS:

- Birds must always remain in their cages.
- Bird's cages should be covered with a blanket at night so that they and everyone else can sleep.

POCKET PETS (Hamsters, Guinea Pigs, Rabbits, etc.)

- These pets should have their bedding/hay changed every couple of days, depending on the size of the pet and the quantity. If an odor is detected, change it sooner.
- In general, these pets do not need a crate. They are usually kept in a "playpen" type of enclosure.

  If there are young children in the shelter, you will need an enclosure with a very small mesh or a glass enclosure to keep little fingers from getting nipped.

Approved Shelter Necessities (ASN) List

		Planned Budget Amount for P-Card purchases by Shelter for 30 days				Digitally Signed:
		$13,000.00	$26,000.00	$65,000.00	$130,000.00	
		Maximum pre-approved quantities for Fulfillment (30 Days)				
Category	**Item**	**50 p Shelter**	**100 p Shelter**	**250 p Shelter**	**500 p Shelter**	**UOM**
Administrative	Pens	100	200	500	1000	each
Administrative	Blue Tape	15	30	75	150	rolls
Administrative	Newsprint	1	2	5	10	pack (50 sheets)
Administrative	Shelter Forms (including new registration form)	400	800	2000	4000	each
Administrative	Folders	100	200	500	1000	each
Administrative	Notepad	50	100	250	500	each
Administrative	Printer Paper	2	4	10	20	packs
Administrative	Binders	15	30	75	150	each
Administrative	Markers	75	150	375	750	each
Administrative	Name tags	200	400	1000	2000	each
Administrative	Wrist-bands	500	1000	2500	5000	each
Administrative	Stapler	5	10	25	50	each
Administrative	3-hold punch	5	10	25	50	each
Administrative	Paperclips	500	1000	2500	5000	each
Administrative	File box	5	10	25	50	each
Administrative	Tote	10	20	50	100	each
Administrative	Bulletin board or white board	3	3	6	6	each
Other	Flashlight	50	100	250	500	each
Other	Batteries	Appropriate # for flashlights				
Other	Red Cross vests	15	20	30	50	each
Other	First-Aid Kit	5	10	25	50	each
Other	Extension Cord	15	15	30	30	each
Other	Power Strip	15	15	30	30	each
Other	Work gloves	20	20	30	40	each
Other	Misc phone chargers	25	50	125	250	each
Feeding Supplies	Hairnet	500	1000	2500	5000	each
Feeding Supplies	Beardnets	500	1000	2500	5000	each
Feeding Supplies	Food serving Gloves (various sizes)	1000	2000	5000	10000	each
Feeding Supplies	Banquet pack	25000	50000	125000	250000	each

Category	Item	50 p shelter	100 p Shelter	250 p Shelter	500 p Shelter	UOM
Feeding Supplies	Plates/Bowls	15000	30000	75000	150000	each
Feeding Supplies	Hot cups	25000	50000	125000	250000	each
Feeding Supplies	Spoodle and other food serving items	25	25	125	250	each
Feeding Supplies	Food thermometer	10	20	50	100	each
Feeding Supplies	Ice chest	10	10	20	30	each
Feeding Supplies	Hot water urn/percolator	4	4	6	8	each
Feeding Supplies	Coffee pot	4	4	6	8	each
Feeding and canteen	MREs/Shelf Stable	As determined by Mass Care leadership				
Feeding and canteen	Ice	As determined by Mass Care leadership/ PO				bags
Feeding and canteen	Breakfast items (cereal, milk, boxed juice, pastry)	As determined by Mass Care leadership/ PO				each
Feeding and canteen	Fruit	As determined by Mass Care leadership/ PO				each
Feeding and canteen	Coffee	As determined by Mass Care leadership/ PO				bags
Feeding and canteen	Bottled Water (64oz per person per day, 16.9oz bottle)	As determined by Mass Care leadership/ PO				each
Feeding and canteen	Snacks (4 snacks per person per day)	As determined by Mass Care leadership/ PO				each
Feeding and canteen	Bottled drinks	As determined by Mass Care leadership/ PO				each
Feeding and canteen	Mini-fridge for feeding	3	6	15	30	each
Communication	Cell phone	1	1	1	1	each
Communication	Laptop/Tablet	1	1	2	2	each
Communication	Printer	1	1	1	1	each
Communication	Internet access and Wi-Fi	1	1	1	1	each

Category	Item	50 p shelter	100 p Shelter	250 p Shelter	500 p Shelter	UOM
Client health	Mini-fridge for medications	2	4	10	20	each
Client health	COVID test kits (must maintain temp control)	As determined by DHS and Mass Care leadership				
Client health	Privacy screens	20	20	40	50	each
Client health	Lockable storage container	3	3	5	7	each
Client health	Sensory kit (IDC may determine higher requirements)	25	50	125	250	kit
Client health	Diabetic liquid drinks	900	1800	4500	9000	each
Client health	Unique dietary meals and snacks	As determined by DHS and Mass Care leadership				
Client health	Health Services Supply Kit	5	10	25	50	kit
Client health	OTC medications as ordered by DHS	As determined by DHS and Mass Care leadership				
Personal Care Items	Comfort Kits	500	1000	2500	5000	each
Personal Care Items	KN-95 masks	500	1000	2500	5000	each
Personal Care	Infant crib	10	20	50	100	each
Personal Care	Infant wipes	150	300	750	1500	package
Personal Care	Pack and play	10	20	50	100	each
Personal Care	Similac original infant formula	100	200	500	1000	canisters
Personal Care	Infant Diaper (various sizes)	1200	2400	6000	12000	each
Personal Care	Adult diapers (various sizes, male & female)	2100	4200	10500	21000	each
Function and Access	Shower chair w/ handrails	7	14	35	70	each
Function and Access	Shower hand sprayer	7	14	35	70	each
Function and Access	Shower mat	20	40	100	200	each
Function and Access	Walker	7	14	35	70	each
Function and Access	Wheelchair (XL size unelss specified)	3	6	15	30	each
Function and Access	Cane	10	20	50	100	each
Function and Access	Commode	10	20	50	100	each
Function and Access	Blender	3	6	15	30	each

Category	Item	50 p shelter	100 p Shelter	250 p Shelter	500 p Shelter	UOM
Sanitation supplies	Sanitization spray	20	40	100	200	bottles
Sanitation supplies	Sanitization wipes	50	100	250	500	each
Sanitation supplies	Hand sanitizer bottles (medium or large size)	25	50	125	250	each
Sanitation supplies	Toilet paper	300	600	1500	3000	rolls
Sanitation supplies	Trash bags	30	60	150	300	boxes
Sanitation supplies	Paper towel	100	200	500	1000	rolls
Signage	Interior signage	3	3	3	6	set
Signage	Exterior signage	3	3	3	6	set
Dormitory items	Standard cot	50	100	250	500	each
Dormitory items	Bariatric cot	10	20	50	100	each
Dormitory items	Inclined headrest cot	15	30	75	150	each
Dormitory items	Blankets	150	300	750	1500	each
Dormitory items	Floor covering under cots	As determined by Facilities				
Dormitory items	Bath Towels	200	400	1000	2000	each
Dormitory items	Box Fan	5	10	25	50	each

Note: This list shows potential quantity maximums for 30 days. Fulfillment manages consumption against limits in support of shelters. List is not an indication of the total material items or amounts a shelter will receive.

Shelter Site Managers may request items that are not on the Approved Shelter Necessities List by communicating with the Fulfillment Delivery Teams, Fulfillment Help Line (when established), or HQ Sheltering Manager. A Disaster Requisition Form 6409 is not required. Such requests are discussed in the Daily Sheltering Support Coordination Meeting for review and Fulfillment acquires and delivers those items to shelter sites upon approval by the AD of Operations/designee.

Cleaning and Maintaining Pet Areas

Details on supporting the cleanliness and order of the pet area in shelters

Typically performed by: *Animal Welfare Partner*
Roles likely to support task: *Facility Manager, HQ Pet Shelter Services Coordinator, HQ Sheltering Manager, Shelter Workers*

Considerations

- Pet owners are responsible for maintaining clean crates for their pets (for example: changing litter boxes, cleaning up and disposal of spilled food or waste).
- Animal welfare partners are responsible for maintaining the overall pet service area.
  - Shelter staff may be asked to assist with basic support such as daily sweeping and mopping.
  - In instances where shelter staff is unable to support, HQ Shelter Managers may consider janitorial services to support.
- Related **Mass Care Groups Standards**
  - Initiating Mass Care Services
  - Prioritizing Mass Care Services
- Related **Sheltering Activity Standards**
  - Shelter Site Operations Standards
  - Household Pets and Service Animals

What to do

Store and use animal-safe cleaning products safely

- Use only animal-safe sanitizing products around animals.
- Carefully follow the specific instructions and cautions for products.
- Never use bleach in the animal room, or on items which an animal may come in direct contact.
- Keep cleaning/sanitizing products and chemicals away from pets. Store them in isolated locations that are not near animals.

Tasks when opening a shelter

- Post signage indicating locations for “Pet Relief Area” and “Pet Service Area.”
- Place waste receptacles in identified relief and service areas.
- Place “pet waste bags” dispenser in the relief area; additional rolls should be available at the reception desk or near the shelter exit.
- Place hand sanitizer in relief and pet service area.
- Provide EPA-registered/veterinary approved disinfecting wipes or spray and follow instructions for use.
- Ensure cleaning tools (broom, mop and approved pet friendly sanitizers) are available for animal welfare partners for use in the pet services area.

Tasks to complete daily

- Cleaning all work tables in the pet services area with approved pet friendly sanitizer.
- Empty all waste receptacles in service and relief areas. Check these locations throughout the day to avoid overfilling/becoming too heavy.
- Sweep and mop floors daily.

- Store pet food securely to avoid attracting wildlife, rodents, and insects.
- Ensure no open food left outside a pet's crate.
- Block rodent entrances.
- Tell your supervisor about any pest or rodent sightings immediately.

Tasks to complete as needed

- Replace preventive items (for example: Floor covering, barriers, etc.) proactively to minimize damage
- Replace worn or damaged receptacles.
- Refill pet waste bag dispensers.
- Refill hand sanitizer dispensers.

Related Articles

Sheltering Toolkit
Resources for Red Cross workers supporting the sheltering activity during readiness and shelter operations

Initial Tasks for Opening a Shelter
Priority actions to complete when opening a shelter

Receiving and Obtaining Initial Sheltering Supplies
Steps for workers at shelters to take to obtain supplies for the shelter.

Questions

For assistance contact **Pets@redcross.org**

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Report Content To Author

Cleaning Cots at the Shelter

Instructions for the steps needed to effectively clean cots after they have been used in shelters

Typically performed by: Shelter Site Manager
Roles likely to support task: Shelter Shift Supervisors, Shelter Workers, Disaster Health Services

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    - Engage Disaster Health Services or Public Health for situation-specific guidance when cots have been exposed to blood, urine, bowel movements or other unique germs
  - Prepare cleaned cots for return to storage
  - Moving cots to another location to be cleaned
    - Prepare the cots for movement
    - Relocating cots for cleaning
- Related Articles
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Considerations

- Shelter workers are responsible for cleaning the cots assigned to a shelter.
- Following standardized procedures is necessary to ensure that cots are sanitary, do not endanger others' health, and are ready for use by a future client.
  - Improper cleaning of cots may lead to mildew and damage.
  - Disinfecting cots incorrectly may lead to infection risks.
- All cots are to be clean and dry prior to the shelter closing, and all cots that have been used must be cleaned and returned to stock prior to the DRO ending.

What to do

Determine where cots will be cleaned

- Identify a well-ventilated location where cots can be cleaned.
  - Whenever possible, use a tent or covered area.
- When space, restrictions, or resources do not allow the cots to be cleaned at the shelter, the HQ Sheltering Manager will coordinate with Logistics to move cots to an off-site location.

Gather necessary supplies

- Nitrile gloves
- Face masks

- Coveralls
- Scrub brush
- Dish soap
- Hospital-grade disinfectant solution or wipes (e.g., Clorox Healthcare Hydrogen Peroxide Disinfectant Wipes)
    - Ensure the product is EPA-registered and appears on the EPA List N. Follow the manufacturer's instructions for contact time.
- Water hose attachment

Clean and disinfect cots

Cots that have been used by clients

- Follow the safety directions of the disinfectant solution manufacturer and wear gloves, a mask, and plastic coveralls while cleaning a cot to protect the skin from exposure.
- Sweep off any debris or vacuum the exterior surfaces of the cot.
- Spray-wash each cot with a water hose sprayer attachment.
- Brush the entire cot with a scrub brush or cloth using a solution of liquid dishwashing detergent and water.
    - Replace cloths frequently when using a cloth.
- Rinse the entire cot thoroughly with clean water to remove all detergent residue.
- Allow the cot to dry, or wipe/shake off any standing water, so the surface is no more than slightly damp before disinfecting.
    - Applying disinfectant to a wet cot dilutes the solution and reduces its effectiveness.
- Disinfect the cot with hospital-grade disinfectant solution spray or wipes. Follow the instructions on the disinfectant's label, including the required wet contact time — the surface must stay visibly wet with disinfectant for the full time listed.
- Allow the cot to air dry for at least 24 hrs.
    - Place the cot in sunlight, if possible.
    - Longer drying times may be needed in humid environments.
- Return the clean, dried, usable cots to the original bag sleeve and/or cardboard box.

Cots that have been set up but not used by clients

- Cots that have been opened but not used should be visually inspected to confirm they remain clean and do not require full cleaning and disinfection.
- Disinfect the clean cots by either spraying the cot with hospital-grade disinfectant solution or using hospital-grade disinfectant wipes.
- Follow the instructions on the disinfectant's label.
- Allow a few minutes for rapid drying.
- Return the cot to the original bag sleeve and/or cardboard box.
- Return to the shelter trailer or stack as directed for pick-up.

Engage Disaster Health Services or Public Health for situation-specific guidance when cots have been exposed to blood, urine, bowel movements or other unique germs

- It may be necessary to utilize other cleaning and disinfectant approaches or salvage certain cots.

Prepare cleaned cots for return to storage

- Mark cots to identify those that are:
    - clean and ready for storage
    - broken and need to be disposed of with medical waste
    - broken and can be disposed of with general garbage
- Update the inventory sheet to reflect the number of discarded cots.
- Return to the shelter trailer or stack as directed for pick-up.

Moving cots to another location to be cleaned

Prepare the cots for movement

- Each cot must be clearly marked as “dirty” before being removed from the shelter and cleaned elsewhere.
- Sweep off any debris or vacuum the exterior surfaces of the cot.
- Do not place dirty cots in bag sleeves or boxes.

Relocating cots for cleaning

- Establish a plan and designate an accountable Red Cross leader to ensure that dirty cots are not mixed with clean cots during the move and are cleaned before the end of the DRO.
- When dirty cots have been placed in a regional shelter trailer prior to being cleaned, post prominent signage inside and outside the shelter trailer indicating the cots are dirty so that they are not accidentally used for a future response.
- Vehicles such as ERVs actively being used to transport food should not be used to transport dirty cots.

Related Articles

Coordinating the Closing or Consolidation of Shelters
Guidance for sheltering leadership on necessary steps to take in advance of closing shelters

Closing a Shelter Site
Instructions for planning for and implementing the closing of a shelter site.

Sheltering Toolkit
Resources for Red Cross workers supporting the sheltering activity during readiness and shelter operations

Questions

For assistance contact **Sheltering@redcross.org**

Does this page require a review? Click the link below to inform the author.

Report Content To Author

Tip Sheet: Client Volunteers in Shelters

In a well-operated shelter, clients develop a sense of community, and some residents want to assist other clients as Red Cross volunteers. These clients can help support the daily operation of the shelter. Helping to operate the shelter provides clients with meaningful activities, improves morale, and may reduce the staffing needs of the Red Cross and its partners.

Clients Are Different from Other Red Cross Volunteers

Remember that clients are not event-based volunteers (EBVs). Shelter residents:

- Have not been oriented to Red Cross fundamental principles;
- Have not been made aware of Sheltering procedures;
- Have not been background checked;
- Have a primary focus of developing their own recovery plan. Engaging in shelter-support tasks must not shift their focus from their recovery.

These concerns mean that there is a limited subset of tasks that clients may be asked to support.

Making Opportunities Available

All clients should be given the opportunity to participate as volunteer workers.

- Make an announcement that you are seeking volunteers in a residents meeting;
- Create a list of volunteers;
- Rotate through the list when tasks are available.

Tasks for Client Volunteers

Keep the assignment of client volunteers specific and task-oriented. Tasks may be as short as 10-15 minutes and normally should not take longer than 1 hour. If completing a task requires more time, use several client volunteers.

Tasks should be relatively simple and clearly explained to the client volunteer, and volunteers should be paired with a Red Cross worker carrying out the task or work under a supervisor.

Appropriate Tasks for Client Volunteers:

- Wiping down tables before or after meals;
- Picking up litter in the dormitory, shelter, or on shelter grounds;
- Emptying trash containers;
- Unloading and stacking supplies;
- Helping with inventories of supplies;
- Helping at the information desk;
- Helping distribute personal supplies at the distribution desk;

- Sweeping floors;
- Refilling soap dispensers and replacing hand sanitizer bottles;
- Taking down and cleaning used tables, chairs, or cots.

Inappropriate Tasks for a Client Volunteer

- Anything a Red Cross volunteer would not be asked to do;
- Anything that puts them at risk, including heavy lifting;
- Anything involving confidential information;
- Anything involving children or vulnerable persons;
- Anything involving use of any machinery;
- Tasks involving government agencies or partners;
- Anything that would imply they have any level of authority over other clients.

Some Do's and Don'ts for Client Volunteers

Do …

- Set boundaries and expectations for the task to be accomplished.
- Provide training.
- Make it clear to whom client volunteers report and should go with any questions.
- Encourage client volunteers to report items that are outside their purview (like facility repairs needed) to their supervisor.
- *Provide* recognition during shelter resident meetings, perhaps with a small trinket or pin as a memento (only if there are enough for every client volunteer).
- Avoid any appearance of favoritism involving client volunteers.
- Avoid any appearance that client volunteers have a special position or authority in the shelter.
- Let the district and/or DRO Headquarters know if the shelter is receiving significant help from client volunteers so they can better allocate EBVs to where they are most needed.
- Encourage clients to volunteer again with the Red Cross once their recovery is complete.

Do Not …

- Allow client volunteers to wear Red Cross branded clothing or a vest.
- Create an ID badge for them. It can be misinterpreted by others.
- Allow client volunteers to work without a Red Cross person nearby, just as we prefer Red Cross volunteers to work in partnership.
- Allow client volunteers to ride in a Red Cross vehicle without approval from the district or DRO Headquarters. Their work should be confined to the shelter site.
- Include client volunteers in Red Cross volunteer staff meetings. Hold a separate meeting for them if necessary or desired.

Creating a Client-First Sheltering Environment

Steps for workers in shelters are to build a climate of putting clients first

Typically performed by: *Shelter Site Manager*
Roles likely to support task: *Shelter Shift Supervisors, Shelter Workers, Client Care*

Considerations

- The first step in Client-First Sheltering is establishing safe and accessible places for displaced people and their pets.
- Some clients may stay in the dormitory overnight, while others may come to the shelter for meals and recovery support – we strive to help everyone needing our assistance.
- Our clients have many cultural backgrounds and value systems that lead to differing levels of concern about privacy and modesty.
- Due to the disaster and communal living, clients will lose some privacy and may need our support and guidance to maintain their dignity.
- Services at shelters is always be provided for people displaced by the disaster including those with disabilities and other access and functional needs, transgender and nonbinary clients, and regardless of pre-disaster housing status or citizenship.
- Related **Shelter Activity Standards:**
  - Shelter Site Operations Standards

What to do

When interacting with clients:

- Introduce yourself and your role.
- Treat clients with dignity and respect, strive to meet clients' individual needs, and support them in their own recovery.
  - Address clients by their formal name, or a polite greeting such as, "Good morning, Sir/Ma'am."
  - Communicate with clients regularly to understand their concerns.
  - Listen carefully, show courtesy and empathy, and accommodate them as much as possible.
- Respect the client's privacy.
  - Request permission from the client when you want to help them move or inspect their personal possessions.
  - Red Cross workers are not to pick up or otherwise touch a client's pet.
  - Treat mobility devices as extensions of the client's body and ask before touching.
- Respect the client's independence.
  - Ask clients if they would like help and what would be helpful to them.
  - Allow clients to make their own choices and decisions as often as possible.
- Communicating with clients whose primary language is not English.
  - If possible, assign a worker who speaks the same language as the client.
  - Contact the HQ Sheltering Manager if translation support is needed.
  - Use an online translation application such as Google Translate.
  - Communicate via writing or text messaging when interpreting is not readily available.

Related Articles

Evicting a Client from a Shelter

Guidance for evicting a client from a shelter

Typically performed by: Shelter Site Manager
Roles likely to support task: HQ Sheltering Manager, Client Care, AD Externa lRelations

Considerations

- It is sometimes necessary to evict clients for violation of rules, physical fights, verbal abuse, disturbances, or other reasons
- Eviction usually occurs after several warnings and when efforts to resolve the issues have not the altered the situation
    - Evictions may occur without warning in cases of physical attacks or when the threat to other clients and staff is too great to allow the person to remain
- Evictions occur for individuals and not entire households.
    - Family members who are not involved in the behavior that led to the eviction are welcome to remain at the shelter
- The Shelter Site Manager has the authority to determine when a client should be evicted from a shelter
- Related Shelter Activity Standards:
    - Shelter Operations
    - Shelter Safety and Client Standards
    - Household Pets and Service Animals

What to do

Making the decision to evict a client

- Consult the HQ Sheltering Manager, Disaster Mental Health staff, Disaster Health Services staff, HQ Pet Coordinator and other relevant service partners who can provide knowledge or perspective on the situation.
- Consider any unresolved issues, client information, and alternative resolutions before making a final decision.

Notify leadership

- When the decision is made to evict a client, contact the HQ Sheltering Manager or Mass Care or Operations leadership who informs External Relations in advance of potential inquiries from public officials or the media.

Perform the eviction

- Make sure at least two Red Cross workers are present (including the on-duty shelter site leader)
    - It may be helpful to have security and/or law enforcement personnel, and Disaster Mental Health present when that is possible
- Have as few other clients and staff around as possible

- Be calm and firm when informing the client that they must leave the shelter
  - Remember that family members who are not involved in the behavior that led to the eviction are welcome to choose to remain at the shelter

- After you inform the client:
  - Allow them enough time to gather their belongings and pets
  - Remove any wristbands or ID allowing shelter entry
  - Escort the client to the exit
  - Ask the client not to return to the shelter or go to any other Red Cross shelters

Document the details of the eviction

- Record client information, why they were evicted, who handled the eviction, and names of witnessing personnel in SCIA as a comment and in the check-out section
  - If present law enforcement or security were present, record the officer's name, badge number, and case number in the Shelter Site Manager's Log

- Ensure the clienthas been checked out of SCIA, and that their reason for checkout is marked as "*evicted*"
- Inform Shelter Supervisors, reception/registration workers, dormitory workers, security personnel, and the HQ Sheltering Manager.
- Ask the HQ Sheltering Manager about any additional steps that need to be taken.
- The HQ Sheltering Manager determines what to tell the Shelter Site Managers and workers at other shelters about the eviction.

Related Articles

Sheltering Toolkit
Resources for Red Cross workers supporting the sheltering activity during readiness and shelter operations

Questions

For assistance contact **Sheltering@redcross.org**

Evicting a Client from a Shelter V1 2026.05.05 Mass Care - Sheltering

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Report Content To Author

Tip Sheet: Interacting with Shelter Clients

An important role of all shelter workers is to interact with clients. This is important because it makes each client feel cared for and helps improve morale in the shelter. It also helps build situational awareness for shelter management so we can improve the shelter experience and better serve needs. Having an outgoing personality and starting conversations is natural for some people, but others are more reserved and initiating conversations may feel less natural. This sheet presents some tips for talking with clients.

As you move through the shelter to carry out other tasks, greet people with a smile, wave or say "hello," even if you don't recognize them from earlier interactions. Remember, sometimes there are no words needed, and just sitting with a person without talking provides needed support in the moment.

Ask Some Simple Questions:

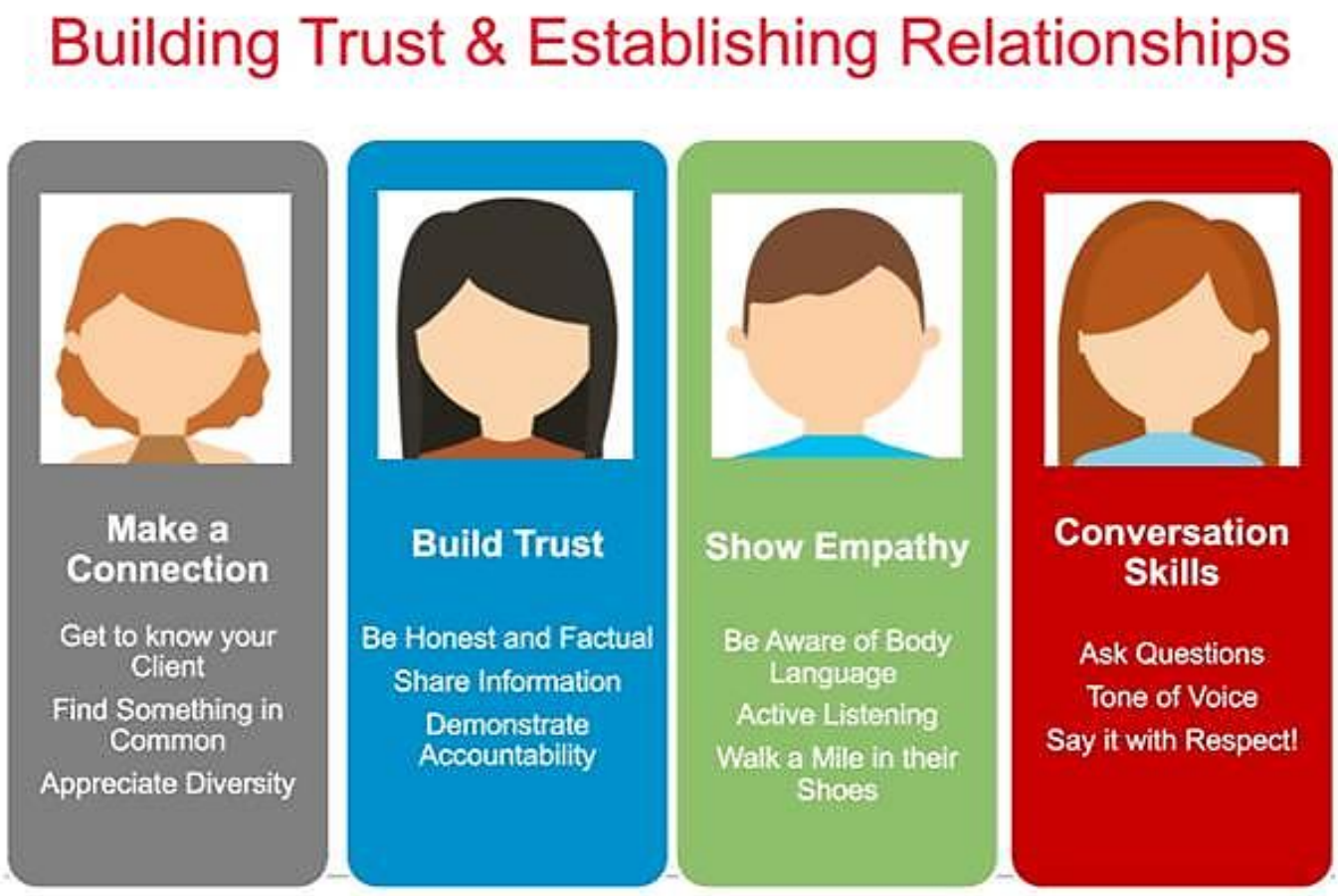
- Ask about shelter conditions: "Are you warm enough?", "How are the food portions?" or "How's the food?"
- Ask about them: "How are you doing?" or "Do you have what you need?"
- Ask about their children: "How are your children doing?" or "Do your children need anything?"
- Ask about their networks: "Have you been able to connect with family members, friends or co-workers?"
- Ask basic questions about recovery: "Have you talked with the caseworkers yet?", "Do you know when you'll be allowed to go back to look at your home?"

Have Longer Conversations:

- Approach slowly within client's line of vision.
- Before speaking, try to picture yourself in their situation.
- Try to gain eye-level contact; stand or sit next to them.
- Make eye contact unless this seems to make the client uncomfortable.
- Introduce yourself; ask their name.
- Ask both open-ended and close-ended questions and talk about the disaster, the shelter, or anything else they want to discuss.
- Actively listen and demonstrate your care.
- Allow the client to tell their story.
- Some clients may be more comfortable while actively engaged (walking with you, eating a meal together, or assisting in a shelter task).
- Group conversations may take the pressure off, so sit and chat with a group of people.

Information Sharing

Anytime you learn useful information about shelter services or needs, tell the Shelter Shift Supervisor. If you learn information about personal needs or a client's transition out of the shelter, tell the Shelter Shift Supervisor, Shelter Resident Transition Supervisor, or relevant Disaster Health Services / Disaster Mental Health worker.



Interview Do's and Don'ts for Red Cross Workers

This document provides suggestions for conducting interviews with the media



Don't do an interview with someone who walks up to you and asks for one. Instead, make sure that you've first vetted the request with your local communications colleague prior to participation.

Don't fake an answer. Don't feel you have to answer every question posed by a reporter. If it is outside of your area of expertise, admit it.

Don't say "No Comment." It will take years to overcome the negative publicity when the public hears you say "No comment." There are times when you shouldn't answer a reporter's question: when it's proprietary information; or when there is pending legal action and your attorneys say you can't comment about specifics. However, explain that and then bridge to information that you would like the public to know in the subject area, even if you cannot comment on the specific question.

Don't go off the record. The information you give "off the record" may end up in the newspaper story or on the air. Although it may

not be attributed directly to you, it's not worth the risk of having potentially damaging information associated with you.

Don't answer multiple questions. Don't feel compelled to try to remember three or four questions that a reporter asks in a group. That's designed to intimidate you. Pick out the one you want to answer, or the last one asked, or group them into one subject area and select the sound bite you want the public to hear.

Don't fill the embarrassing silence. Let's assume you've just given your answer to a reporter, and you've Stopped!. Then, the interviewer looks up from the reporter's pad at you and doesn't say anything, or leaves a microphone in your face and is silent. It's a ploy to lure you into saying something that is not well thought out, maybe something you normally wouldn't say to the reporter. You fill the embarrassing silence and it could be disastrous. Don't!

Don't lose your cool. You will alienate the print reporter. In a broadcast interview, all that will end up on the air is you losing your temper, never the reporter's provocation.

Don't ask to review or edit the story. That request suggests that you might want to censor the story. A good reporter won't allow that. However, make sure the reporter knows how to contact you if more information is needed.



Do remember your relationship with the reporter. The reporter is not a judge and you are not a witness under subpoena. You do not

have to accommodate the reporter who tries to badger you or lead you down the primrose path. You are an expert with knowledge in specific areas. The reporter must write a story or get something "in the can" before the next newscast. The reporter is a vehicle through which you reach your public.

Do listen carefully to the entire question. Don't allow yourself to become so enamored with the style of the reporter that you forget to concentrate on the question and how you can effectively inform the reporter's public in the subject area.

Do look at the reporter's eyes. The reporter or the viewing public will distrust anyone who looks far away from the reporter's eyes, as though they must be hiding something. Naturally, you can't stare constantly at a reporter, so give occasional relief with a brief glance away, then back to the reporter's eyes.

Do establish your own intensity level. The great majority of interviewees are so preoccupied with the content of their message that they forget to show enthusiasm. You cannot afford to be blase about your ideas or your cause. Your enthusiasm conveys that you care. Therefore, establish your own intensity level that says "I really care about this." That's infectious. And, it prevents you from the natural tendency to copy the demeanor of the reporter who is interviewing you.

Do tell the truth. Don't open the "dirty linen closet" and tell the reporter all the negatives about you or your organization. But, by all means, tell the truth when asked. The reporter may know the truth, and if you're not forthcoming with it, you lose all credibility.

Do watch your jargon. As with any organization, the Red Cross has its own terms and acronyms. Terms such as ERVs or LDVs are not self-explanatory and the reporter's public may not understand your jargon. Match your language to the knowledge level of the reporter's public, and you cannot possibly be misunderstood.

Do lead the reporter. If there are important points you want to make, lead the reporter into inquiring about those points. For example, in your answer you might say "That's just one of the many ways were being flexible in our service delivery to meet the unique

needs of the victims of this disaster." The reporter is compelled to ask what those "many ways" are.

Do correct mistakes on the spot. Reporters know you're human and can make mistakes during an interview. If you fail to correct them, you lose credibility and so may the reporter. If you correct them immediately, you gain credibility.

Do take control if bullied. Most reporters are responsible journalist who are trying to elicit facts, feelings, opinions and judgements from you. Some reporters use intimidating questions or techniques designed to lure you into making provocative, indiscreet, controversial, titillating or revealing statements. If a reporter uses intimidating techniques - asks you multiple questions, interrupts you, raises voice volume, speeds up questions, invades your space, touches you, recognizing the technique and remaining calm and refusing to be intimidated can put you back in control of the interview.

Do remember why you are doing this interview. You are doing this interview to accomplish your agenda, namely getting the best possible information to the reporter's public about you, your organization or your cause.

Does this page require a review? Click the link below to inform the author.

Report Content To Author

Just-In-Time Sheltering Knowledge and Skill Building Presentations

Instructions to support the delivery of just-in-time learning presentations to the sheltering workforce on DROs

Typically performed by: HQ Sheltering Manager, Disaster Mental Health Manager
Supported by: Mass Care Chief, Client Care Chief, Disaster Spiritual Care Manager, Disaster Health Services Manager, Assistant Director of Operations

Purpose

Improve the client and volunteer experience by enabling DRO leaders to provide timely, focused coaching and support to the sheltering workforce by addressing real-time challenges in their shelters and reinforcing key skills.

Description

Brief, focused learning sessions designed to enhance understanding, confidence, responder resilience, and team cohesion through relevant learning opportunities. By leveraging knowledgeable and available operational leaders to deliver learning content developed by NHQ Activity Leaders at the service delivery site, these aim to:

- Provide foundational understanding about commonly faced challenges in shelters
- Promote productive conversation and discussion amongst responders
- Respect time constraints by fitting learning into daily routines
- Target specific skills or challenges
- Foster a culture of learning without overwhelming staff

What To Do

1. DRO leaders at Daily Sheltering Coordination Meeting identify specific operational challenges at individual shelter sites
2. HQ Sheltering Manager meets with DMH Manager to explore feasibility to deliver Just-In-Time Knowledge and Skill and Building Presentations at some or all shelters
    a. This task can always be led by another Mass Care leader and/or another Client Care leader
    b. These leaders may engage other individuals within their Groups and Activities to support these efforts as appropriate

3. Develop informal plan that addresses these steps:
    a. Review **Topic Presentations** and determine which ones should be delivered, and if there should be additions to include specific situations
    b. Work through HQ Sheltering Manager to review plan with Shelter Site Manager to determine appropriate format and timing to deliver Just-In-Time Presentations at shelters. Consider:
        i. Will the presenters use large newsprint and notecards?
        ii. Will the presenters be able to set up a projector and use slides?
        iii. Will handouts be helpful?
        iv. Will the presentation be delivered during a stand-up meeting? If yes, should chairs be set up in a particular layout?
        v. Identify appropriate team member to prepare materials

4. The presentation(s) are delivered by individuals identified by HQ Sheltering Manager and DMH Manager
5. Individuals involved share update on progress and takeaways at Daily Sheltering Coordination Meeting

Topic Presentations

To download the presentations below, click on the down arrow icon next to the file name in the right column.

Understanding the Influences on Shelter Clients' Behaviors: Explore how pre-disaster and disaster specific influences shape client mindsets and behaviors and guide effective support strategies.

Topic 1 - Understanding Influences on Client Behavior.pptx
22 MB

Additional Support for Shelter Workers: Learn how to navigate urgent and non-urgent referral processes to better support client needs and promote overall well-being

Topic 2 - Additional Support Options for Shelter Workers.pptx
22 MB

De-escalation Techniques: Learn effective communication and behavioral strategies to safely reduce tension and prevent conflict in high-stress situations.

Topic 3 - De-escalation Techniques.pptx
21 MB

Preparing for Difficult Conversations: Gain skills to approach sensitive topics with empathy, compassion, and confidence to foster meaningful engagement.

Topic 4 - Preparing for Difficult Conversations.pptx
21 MB

Tactics for Developing Psychological Resilience: Discover self-care practices to build inner strength, adaptability, and sustained emotional health in challenging environments.

Topic 5 - Tactics for Developing Psychological Resilience.pptx
21 MB

Related Articles

When and How to Offer Disaster Mental Health Services to Clients and Responders
Overview of when/how to talk with clients and workers about Disaster Mental Health services.

When to Refer to Disaster Mental Health Reference Card
Quick reference card covering when to refer clients to Disaster Mental Health.

Working with Disaster Spiritual Care in Shelters
Describes how to provide disaster spiritual care services in Red Cross service delivery sites, such as shelters.

"When to Refer to Disaster Spiritual Care" Wallet Card
Guidance for making referrals to Disaster Spiritual Care and identifying spiritual distress

Questions?

For assistance contact **sheltering@redcross.org**.

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Report Content To Author

Keeping Shelter Clients Informed about the Disaster and Red Cross Services

Guidance for workers at shelters on effectively meeting the information needs of clients

Typically performed by: Shelter Site Manager
Roles likely to support task: Shelter Shift Supervisors, Shelter Workers

Considerations

- Update clients frequently to help them understand the disaster, their situation, the shelter, and how to begin moving towards recovery.
  - Regular communication helps stop rumors or inaccurate information.
- Client meetings create a better shelter experience and build a sense of community.
- Helpful tools for communication include bulletin boards, posters and signage, newsletters, and television and newspapers access.
- Related **Shelter Activity Standards**:
  - Shelter Operations
  - Shelter Safety and Client Standards

What to do

Establish an Information Area

- In an area near Reception, provide information to clients in the form of fliers and bulletin board postings.
- Provide daily updates on weather, reunification, disaster situation, upcoming events at the shelter, available community resources and services including where services are available to support livestock and other large animals.
- Review the fliers provided by partner organizations to ensure they are appropriate for clients and align with our mission.
- Make sure all information is accessible to all clients.
  - Engage support from Headquarters as needed to communicate with clients with disabilities and other access and functional needs, including those whose first language is not English.

Create a list of talking points to answer common client questions

- Seek guidance from HQ Sheltering Manager to ensure appropriate messaging.
- Review and update on appropriate intervals.

Host client meetings

- Be sure meetings are are accessible to all clients, including those who are Deaf or Hard of Hearing, have limited English proficiency, or have other communication accessibility needs.
- In the meetings, cover the following:
  - Disaster updates, recovery information and any known timeline about the shelter status
  - Volunteer opportunities at the shelter

    - Concerns that are affecting the client experience at the shelter
    - Shelter rules and safety information such as:
        - The location of fire extinguishers
        - Evacuation routes
        - The Shelter Emergency Action Plan
        - How to keep personal items and valuables safe
- Allow time for client questions and suggestions and for discussion of issues that clients wish to raise for the Red Cross to address.

Control rumors and incorrect information

- Anticipate that clients may be feeling uncertainty
- Inform your supervisor of any rumors you believe DRO leadership needs to address
- Communicate any talking points you receive

Pet information

- Ensure all information about community-based pet services is available at the pet area.

Related Information

Sheltering Toolkit
Resources for Red Cross workers supporting the sheltering activity during readiness and shelter operations

Sharing Key Information Between the Shelter and the HQ Sheltering Manager
Types of information and methods of communication shared between shelters and DRO headquarters.

Creating a Client-First Sheltering Environment
Steps for workers in shelters are to build a climate of putting clients first

Questions

For assistance contact **Sheltering@redcross.org**

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Report Content To Author

Maintaining Safety and Health in Shelters

Guidance for workers at shelters on keeping people healthy and safe

Typically performed by: Shelter Site Manager
Roles likely to support task: HQ Sheltering Manager, Shelter Shift Supervisors, Shelter Workers, Disaster Health Services

Considerations

- Keeping everyone safe is our priority.
- Natural hazards, facility hazards, safety concerns and poor environmental health threaten client and worker safety.
- The Shelter Site Manager and all shelter workers are responsible for identifying and responding to all potential health and safety hazards.
- Congregate shelters may increase the risk of exposure to infectious diseases for our clients and workforce.
- While Red Cross maintains responsibility to manage the shelter, public health authorities maintain the legal responsibility and authority to act involving infectious disease and public health.
- It's natural that the close living environment for individuals from different families and communities may lead to people feeling unsafe.
- Related **Shelter Activity Standards**:
  - Shelter Operations
  - Household Pets and Service Animals
  - Shelter Safety and Client Standards

What to do

Prepare for emergencies at the shelter

- Complete the **Safety in Shelters/Emergency Action Plan** within 72 hours of opening.
- Brief the staff and keep the plan available in case of an emergency.
- Identify the location of first-aid kits, AEDs, fire extinguishers and emergency supplies.
- Order necessary safety items that are not already on site.

Inspect the facility

- Conduct shelter shift **inspections** at the beginning of each shift.
- Inspect inside and outside frequently to identify potentially dangerous situations or issues. Check for the following issues:
  - Lack of accessibility
  - Signs of excessive wear and tear
  - Obstructed emergency exits
  - Any hazards, including fire or trip hazards
  - Obstructed aisles or inaccessible routes within the shelter
  - Areas in need of cleaning
  - Inadequate lighting
  - Damaged or illegible signage that needs to be replaced, especially after heavy wind or rain

Report safety issues identified in the shelter inspection

- The Shift Supervisor or designated individual fills out the **Shift Inspection Form**.
- The Shelter Site Manager reviews, prioritizes, and records what needs to be addressed in the Daily Shelter Report, or other appropriate tool.

Respond to facility hazards

- Mark holes, loose tiles, exposed wiring, or liquid on the floors with a safety cone or floor sign, and caution tape.
- Assign a worker to guard the area until it can be addressed if the hazard is severe.
- Mop up any spills if custodial staff isn't present.
- Immediately report hazards requiring facility action to HQ Sheltering Manager who reports the hazard to the facility owner and the Logistics section.

Respond to injuries to clients, workers, visitors and animals housed at the shelter

- When an injury occurs or is reported, request assistance from onsite Disaster Health Services or EMTs assigned to the shelter.
    - In the event of serious injuries, immediately contact 911 and provide emergency first-aid until their arrival.

- In the event of injuries to animals housed at the shelter, the Shelter Site Manager immediately contacts the animal welfare agency on site, or the Pet Services Coordinator, to arrange for appropriate veterinary care.
- In the event of injuries caused by household pets or service animals:
    - Immediately obtain medical support for the injury.
    - The animal welfare agency confines the animal and notifies the jurisdiction's animal control officer (ACO). If there is no animal welfare partner on site, the Shelter Site Manager should inform the Pet Services Coordinator and request they notify the ACO or Department of Health.
    - Shelter Site Manager immediately informs the pet owner of the incident and that the animal is being confined for observation.

- The Shelter Site Manager or designee documents all details of accidents and injuries including names of witnesses and the details of the response.
    - Seek direction from Headquarters on any additional requirements for reporting.

Respond to infectious diseases at the shelter

- Work closely with Disaster Health Services and public health officials to determine what steps need to be taken when a client has a suspected or confirmed communicable disease.
- Report any signs of food-related illness to Disaster Health Services.
    - Use **Responding to Norovirus f**or guidance in handling norovirus.

- During a pandemic or other public health emergency:
    - Follow all protocols as directed by Public Health.
    - Confirm there are enough sanitation and safety supplies for the next few days of shelter operations.
    - Stay current with the latest precautionary guidance and protocols.
    - Educate clients and shelter staff about disease prevention measures.
    - Establish an isolation care area when directed to do so by Disaster Health Services.
    - Follow Public Health sanitation guidance when closing the shelter.

Respond to bed bugs and lice infestations at the shelter

- See **Responding to Bed Bugs** for guidance in handling bed bugs.
- See **Responding to Lice** for guidance in handling lice.

Keep the shelter clean

- Clean and sanitize the shelter regularly.
  - Advise HQ Sheltering Manager when outside janitorial/cleaning services is needed.
- Provide hand washing stations and hand sanitizer throughout the shelter, especially in high traffic areas and at the start of the food service line.
- Pick up litter and empty the trash.
- Sanitize all high-touch areas with disinfectant at the beginning of each shift.
  - Wipe down the dormitory registration and servicedesks, light switches, door handles and push plates.
  - Clean and sanitize the food serviceand dining areas before and after meals.
- Clean restrooms and showers as often as necessary.
- Clean and inspectused cots.

Maintain sanitation and regular cleaning in the pet services area

- Ensure hand washing stations are available.
- Empty waste receptacles frequently in pet room and relief areas.
- Clean floors using appropriate animal-safe cleaner.

Establish refuge areas at the shelter

- Designate a refuge area for people to take temporary refuge during threats such as gale force winds or tornadoes.
  - Identify a safe space located in an interior enclosed hallway or room if possible, which offer the most protection.
  - Allocate a minimum of 15 square feet for every person in the shelter (clients and workers)
  - Be sure to identify this area in the Emergency Action Plan
  - Address concerns for people who feel unsafe around animals

Fears related to animals

- Establish methods to enable clients and workers who feel unsafe near pets to remain separated from animals.

Related Articles

Creating a Client-First Sheltering Environment
Steps for workers in shelters are to build a climate of putting clients first

Identifying the Safest Refuge Area at a Shelter
Guidance for workers at shelters on establishing a location for clients and workers for temporary protection from danger

Gather and Share Essential Information to Support the Initiation of Sheltering
Guidance for sheltering leadership at DRO Headquarters on the data and information that supports the start of shelter operations

Prepare for Daily Sheltering Coordination Meeting
Guidance for sheltering leadership at DRO Headquarters on necessary actions to take in advance of the daily sheltering coordination meeting

Supporting DRO leadership in Coordinating and Prioritizing Sheltering
Guidance for sheltering leadership at DRO Headquarters to enable our mission essential function of sheltering to be the priority of all DRO leadership

Maintaining Security at the Shelter
Guidance for workers in shelters on establishing and maintaining a secure and safe operating location

Sheltering Toolkit

Maintaining Security at the Shelter

Guidance for workers in shelters on establishing and maintaining a secure and safe operating location

Typically performed by: Shelter Site Manager
Roles likely to support task: HQ Sheltering Manager, AD Logistics, DRO Safety Officer

Considerations

- In most cases, shelter workers are relied on to maintain a safe environment for all.
- If the client population grows and complexity of the sheltering operation, then law enforcement or private security officers may be needed.
    - While it's essential to keep the shelter, clients and workforce safe, the presence of law enforcement may create uneasiness among some people or deter certain clients from seeking Red Cross assistance.
    - Private security must understand that the shelter is a temporary home for clients, and their safety must be ensured without compromising their dignity and privacy.
    - Private security is not authorized to remove clients from the shelter without coordination and approval

from the Shelter Site Manager (see **Evicting a Client from the Shelter** task sheet).

- Related **Shelter Activity Standards**:
  - Shelter Operations
  - Household Pets and Service Animals
  - Non-Traditional Sheltering
  - Shelter Safety and Client Standards

What to do

Arranging and working with outside security

- Identify when additional security is needed/
  - Discuss security concerns with the HQ Sheltering Manager and work with other leaders to arrange security personnel.
  - Arrange for a temporary solution(such as local law enforcement) while procuring a private security service.

- Guide law enforcement or private security at the shelter.
  - Coordinate resources they may need with the supervisor of the security agency, such as meals, workspace, pop-up canopy, etc.
  - Inform them of all areas of the shelter where patrols are necessary and ask for their advice on other areas.
    - Generally, security officers are not e permanently positioned at the entrance of the shelter or in the reception area.

  - Aim for a balance between maintaining security and creating a welcoming and comfortable environment.

Maintaining security with Red Cross Staff

When Red Cross staff maintains security, they receive direction from the Shelter Site Manager and are responsible for the following:

- Restrict entry to authorized people.
    - Close the facility perimeter to visitors and control the entry of new clients.
    - Only allow entry to authorized people.
    - Only pet owners, authorized Red Cross workforce and animal welfare partners may be admitted into the pet area.

- Monitor the inside and outside areas.
    - The Shelter Site Manager advises all the areas (including pet services area) and schedule for patrols,.
    - Two workers are assigned to patrol the perimeter together.
    - Check that all outside doors are closed and locked from the outside but can be opened from the inside in case of an emergency.
    - Report any illegal activity to law enforcement.

- Watch for suspicious activity
    - Notify the Shelter Site Manager if you notice suspicious activity inside or outside of the shelter.
    - Call 911 for urgent situations when the Shelter Site Manager is unavailable.
    - Do not investigate suspicious activity on your own.

Related Information

Maintaining Safety and Health in Shelters
Guidance for workers at shelters on keeping people healthy and safe

Determining Shelter Layout
Details on effectively establishing a physical organization of a shelter site in order to deliver services to standards

Sheltering Toolkit
Resources for Red Cross workers supporting the sheltering activity during readiness and shelter operations

Managing Unaccompanied or Displaced Minors and Reports of a Missing Child at a Shelter

Guidance on necessary actions workers in shelters must take to protect unaccompanied, displaced and missing children

Typically performed by: Shelter Site Manager
Roles likely to support task: HQ Reunification Manager, HQ Sheltering Manager, Shelter Shift Supervisors, Client Care section, Integrated Care Condolence Team

Considerations

- The Shelter Site Manager must immediately prioritize safety and reunification efforts for unaccompanied or displaced minors in shelter
- Disaster Mental Health workers are to provide parents or guardians seeking a *missing child* compassion and information on resources.
- Every effort must be made to make these children feel welcome and safe, and to ensure their privacy is protected.
- The law and our **Fundamental Principles** require that this guidance is followed with sensitivity and close attention to detail.
- Shelter Site Managers are responsible for the care of unaccompanied minors in our shelters until law enforcement or the designated child welfare agency formally takes custody.
- Law enforcement or the official child welfare agency is then responsible for these children until they are reunited with parents or lawful guardians.
- Related Shelter Activity Standards:
    - Shelter Site Operations Standards

Definitions

- An *Unaccompanied Minor* is a person under the age defined by state law* who has been separated from parents, legal guardians, and other relatives; **and** who is not being cared for by an adult who, by law or custom, is responsible for doing so.
    - **Depending on the state or territory, this age may be 18, 19, or 21 years old. State law should be consulted.*
- A *Displaced Minor* is a child without their *customary* primary caregiver (both parents and legal guardian) who is in the company of an adult relative or other adult who, by law or custom, is responsible for their care (licensed childcare provider, schoolteacher, nanny, etc.).

What to Do When a Minor Arrives at the Shelter Without Their Parent or Guardian

Provide immediate care, comfort and for all children who arrive without parents or a legal guardian

- Determine if the child needs emergency medical care and, if so, call 911.
- Engage the Client Care section to meet non-emergency medical or mental health needs.
    - Offer the child water and a snack and create an environment for them to feel safe.
- Be patient, understanding and calm. Do not increase the stress of the minor by discussing the disaster.

Ensure Minor Is Supervised

For an Unaccompanied Minor

- Assign two shelter workers to supervise the minor. If needed, reassign, the tasks typically performed by these workers.
- The two assigned shelter workers continue to supervise the unaccompanied minor until law enforcement or social service/child services agency arrives and officially take custody.

For a Displaced Minor

- A displaced minor does not require supervision by assigned Red Cross workers. While the minor has been separated from their parents or legal guardian, they are in the care of an adult who typically has responsibility for their welfare (for example, coach, teacher, another adult family member, childcare provider).

Gather Information to Assist with Reunification

- If possible, take the minor to a quiet, private space or room. When settled, talk with the minor to gather the information listed below. *Do not assume the information the child provides is accurate or that they will be able to answer all your questions.*
    - Minor's full name and any nicknames
    - Name of minor's parents or guardian and their phone number(s)
    - Minor's date of birth or approximate age
    - Where and when they were found and/or became separated from their parent or guardian (including location, date, time)
    - Note the minor's:
        - *Sex and gender*
        - *Hair and eye color*
        - Clothing they were wearing when they arrival at the shelter
        - How they arrived at the shelter (if known)

Document and Report

- The Shelter Site Manager or designee must contact local law enforcement and be prepared to provide the following information:
    - Identify yourself as a Red Cross worker and that you are calling to report a child at our shelter without parents or guardian
    - Note the officer's contact information, and date and time of call, in the Shelter Manager's Log
    - Request information about local jurisdiction procedures for an unaccompanied child
    - Provide the information given by the minor

- Register the minor on the National Center for Missing and Exploited Children (NCMEC) using either the website or by telephone.
    - **https://umr.missingkids.org/umr**
    - 1-800-THE-LOST (1-800-843-5678)

- Note date and time report was filed in the Shelter Manager's Log
    - Inform the HQ Sheltering Manager of steps taken

- HQ Sheltering Manager informs the HQ Reunification Manager, Mass Care Chief and Assistant Director of Operations.
- Work with internal stakeholders (HQ Sheltering Manager, HQ Reunification Manager, HQ Client Care Manager) and external stakeholders (law enforcement, applicable child welfare agency, and National Center for Missing and Exploited Children) to determine a transfer/reunification plan.
- Work with HQ Sheltering Manager or HQ Reunification Manager to search other shelter locations for the child's parent/guardian.

When working with these children, keep in mind the following:

- If any individual removes the child without presence of law enforcement, notify law enforcement immediately.
- Only law enforcement, the identified child welfare agency, or NCMEC should be permitted to photograph unaccompanied minors or displaced children. All information about a child should be handled confidentially.

What to Do When Someone at a Shelter Reports a Missing Child

- Show empathy and acknowledge their situation; act calmly but with a sense of urgency
- Determine the specific relation of the adult to the sought child (for example, parent, other relation, legal guardian.)
- Encourage the reporting person to contact local law enforcement. Prepare them to be able to provide the following information about the child to authorities:
    - Name
    - Date of birth
    - Sex/Gender
    - Height and weight
    - Hair and eye color
    - Any unique identifiers (birthmarks, injury, eyeglasses, braces, etc.)
    - When and where the child was last seen
    - What they were wearing when last seen
- Recommend that they ask law enforcement to enter the child's information into the FBI's National Crime Information Center's Missing Persons File.
- Encourage them to contact the National Center for Missing and Exploited Children (NCMEC)
    - 1-800-THE-LOST (1-800-843-5678)
    - Let them know there is also a search tool:
        - **https://www.missingkids.org/gethelpnow/search**
    - Inform the HQ Sheltering Manager that a client has reported a missing child
        - The HQ Sheltering Manager will provide the HQ Reunification Manager with the client's name and contact information so they can create a *Sought Person Case*.
    - Inform Client Care section or Integrated Care Condolence Team of the report.

Related Articles

Sheltering Toolkit
Resources for Red Cross workers supporting the sheltering activity during readiness and shelter operations

American Red Cross and the National Center for Missing and Exploited Children MOU
Details the relationship between the American Red Cross and the National Center for Missing and Exploited Children (NCMEC)

Questions

For assistance contact **Sheltering@redcross.org**

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Report Content To Author

Protecting the Dignity and Privacy of Shelter Clients

Guidance for workers in congregate shelters to support the cultural needs of clients in communal living

Typically performed by: Shelter Site Manager
Roles likely to support task: Shelter Shift Supervisors, Shelter Workers, Client Care, Disaster Disability Integration

Considerations

- Clients in shelters may feel uncomfortable and uncertain in a communal living setting and need our support and guidance to help them adjust to their new surroundings.
- Red Cross clients have many cultural backgrounds and value systems, with varying levels of concern about modesty, decency, and privacy.
- Empathy and communication are fundamental elements in protecting the dignity of clients.
    - Red Cross workers strive to help clients feel safe and establish privacy from the public and authorities in the dormitory area.

- Related **Mass Care Group Standards:**
    - Mass Care Service Site Requirements

- Related **Shelter Activity Standards**:
    - Shelter Operations

What to do

Listen and Collaborate

- Listen carefully to client concerns and suggestions regarding personal dignity and accommodate them as much as possible.
- As needed, request guidance from Disaster Disability Integration, Disaster Health Services and Disaster Mental Health.

Address shelter layout and setup concerns

- Establish dressing areas by using privacy screens or small rooms adjacent to the dormitory.
    - Obtain shower curtains and tension rods for use in shower areas when necessary.

- Establish areas for families with small children.
    - Provide a private infant changing area.
    - Provide a breastfeeding room or screened area. Breastfeeding in public is legal in all states and permitted in Red Cross shelters, but some clients prefer the privacy and quiet these areas provide.
    - Provide a space where families with infants can be separate from others if they wish. The space protects unvaccinated infants and reduces noise across the dormitory.

- Provide blue rooms (or sensory kits) for clients in need of a low sensory environment such as autistic clients and those suffering from dementia if possible.

Address service concerns

- Establish a private area for personal or sensitive discussions with clients to respect client privacy during the sharing of information. These may be used for disaster health, mental health and spiritual care discussions, along with those for any other private/confidential issues.
- Provide bags to clients to discreetly carry feminine hygiene, incontinence, and other personal products distributed in the shelter.

Related Articles

Creating a Client-First Sheltering Environment
Steps for workers in shelters are to build a climate of putting clients first

Maintaining Safety and Health in Shelters
Guidance for workers at shelters on keeping people healthy and safe

Providing Assistance for Clients Experiencing Homelessness
Details for workers in shelters and DRO Headquarters on supporting unhoused clients

Serving Clients Legally Required to Register with Government Agencies
Guidance for workers on how to lawfully and discreetly support individuals required to register with government agencies during disasters.

Sheltering Toolkit
Resources for Red Cross workers supporting the sheltering activity during readiness and shelter operations

Questions

For assistance contact **Sheltering@redcross.org**

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Responding to Conflict and Difficult Client Situations in a Shelter

Guidance for workers in shelters on approaches to addressing challenging situations related to clients

Typically performed by: Shelter Site Manager
Roles likely to support task: HQ Sheltering Manager, Shelter Shift Supervisors

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Considerations

- Clients may become tense or upset due to the stress of the disaster, proximity to other clients, or have emotional/health issues.
- Client and worker safety are the priority when responding to challenging to situations.
- When issues among clients disrupt the shelter atmosphere of peacefulness and calm, we must step in and de-escalate.
- Related **Shelter Activity Standards**:
  - Shelter Operations
  - Shelter Safety and Client Standards
  - Household Pets and Service Animals

What to do

- Address rule violations, disruptive behaviors, harassment, or behaviors that interfere with client access to services or sense of safety directly with the client.
  - Try to speak with the client whose behavior is problematic away from the other clients.
  - Have another Red Cross worker with you to observe and take notes.
  - Provide specific examples of the behavior and try to engage the client in formulating solutions.
  - Consider reviewing the Client Welcome Letter and/or the Shelter Rules sign with the client.
- See the guidance below for the specific issue and, as needed, contact the HQ Sheltering Manager for additional guidance.

Agitated or disruptive client

- Try to calm the client.

- Provide Psychological First Aid when appropriate.
- When possible, engage Disaster Mental Health or Disaster Spiritual Care workers.

Clients verbally harassing or abusing other clients or workers

- Separate the individuals.
- Warn them that this behavior is not permitted. Let them know that if this disturbance continues or happens again, law enforcement will be contacted, and they may have to leave the shelter.
- Notify on-site security.
- If they don't stop after a verbal warning, call 911.
- Seek guidance from HQ Sheltering Manager regarding documentation.

Clients threatening to harm themselves or others

- Do one of the following depending on the level of the threat:
  - Call the Shelter Site Manager, Disaster Mental Health, Disaster Spiritual Care, or Security.
  - Call 911.

Clients involved in physical conflict

- Try to address conflicts before they escalate to a physical altercation.
- If a physical conflict occurs:
  - Do not attempt to physically intervene.
  - Call on-site security or 911.
  - Issue verbal warnings to stop the incident right away.
  - When life, safety, or security of a client or worker is at risk, contact the HQ Sheltering Manager immediately.
- Depending on the severity of the incident, evict clients when necessary
  - See the **Evicting Shelter Clients Task** for more information.

Clients is not adhering to shelter pet rules

- Inform the client how they or their pet are not following shelter rules.
- Ensure they understand the rules, ask for their compliance and, when needed work with Client Care team members and animal welfare partners to determine if assistance in complying is needed.
- Provide a warningto the client that continued violations may result in they and theirpets being askedto leave the shelter.
-
- Document in the notification in the client record in SCIA.

Client's service animal is causing disruptions

- The Shelter Site Manager must immediately advise the client that there is an issue regarding their Service Animal and discuss how it might be resolved.
  - Examples: aggression towards clients, disruptive noises, and urinating or defecating inside the shelter.
- If the situation is not resolved and continues, the Shelter Site Manager works with HQ Sheltering Manager, Disaster Disability Integration worker and Pet Services Coordinator to determine the best course of action.

Clients has weapons

- If the client **appears threatening**, immediately contact 911.
- If the client **does not appear threatening**.
  - Do not attempt to take possession of the weapons.
  - Let them know that weapons can't be brought into the shelter for safety reasons, as it's against **Red Cross policy**, children are present, and there's no place to safely store them.

- Ask them to temporarily store the weapons in the trunk of their car or with a friend if possible. If this is not possible call the HQ Sheltering Manager to arrange to store the weapons with law enforcement, a gun shop, or another safe location.

Erratic behavior that suggests emotional or drug-related issues

- Contact Disaster Health Services, Disaster Mental Health Services, or on-site emergency medical personnel who will determine if:
  - Medical care or hospitalization is required
  - The client can remain in the shelter under monitoring
  - The client needs to be isolated from the general population
  - The client needs to go to an alternate shelter

Human trafficking is suspected

- Always be on the lookout for signs that someone may be a victim of human trafficking. Keep these questions in mind:
  - Does a client appear fearful, timid, or submissive?
  - Do they show signs of having been denied food, water, sleep, or medical care?
  - Are they often with someone to whom they defer, or who seems to control them (limiting who they talk to, where they go, etc.)?
  - Do they seem to be coached on what to say?
  - Do they have freedom of movement? Can they freely leave?

- Report concerns but don't confront a suspected trafficker directly or alert a victim to any suspicions.
  - Contact Disaster Mental Health or Disaster Health Services to validate your concern
  - Report the suspected trafficker and/or victim:
    - National Trafficking Resource Center: 1-888-373-7888 (This is a non-governmental organization, not law enforcement or an immigration authority)
    - Federal ICE Tip Line: 866-DHS-2-ICE or 866-347-2423 (Law enforcement referral line to report human trafficking)

- Tell the HQ Sheltering Manager that there was a suspicion of human trafficking and what actions were taken.
- Seek guidance from HQ Sheltering Manager regarding documenting the incident.
- See the **Human Trafficking Awareness Materials** and the **Responding to Suspected Abuse, Neglect, Domestic Violence, or Human Trafficking Job Tool** for more guidance.

Suspected animal abuse, neglect and blood sports

- Animal abuse and blood sports are felonies in all states.
- Report concerns to Shelter Site Manager, who should discuss with animal welfare partner and Pet Services Coordinator to determine if situation is abuse/neglect.
- If you see a crime in action, (for example, dog fighting)
  - Call 911
  - Report the incident Shelter Site Manager who will notify HQ Sheltering Manager of any incidents or reports filed.

Related Articles

Sheltering Toolkit
Resources for Red Cross workers supporting the sheltering activity during readiness and shelter operations

Just-In-Time Sheltering Knowledge and Skill Building Presentations
Instructions to support the delivery of just-in-time learning presentations to the sheltering workforce on DROs

Creating a Client-First Sheltering Environment
Steps for workers in shelters are to build a climate of putting clients first

Responding to Incidents with Pets

Guidance for handling pet-related issues at shelters, including pet owners struggling to care for their pet, injured or sick animals, animal fights and animal bites

Typically performed by: Shelter Site Manager, Shelter Workers, Pet Shelter Services Field Team Members
Roles likely to support task: HQ Sheltering Manager, Mass Care Chief

Considerations

- Pets often experience stress at shelters and may behave in ways they would not at home.
- Owners may struggle to support their pets in an unfamiliar environment with limited resources.
- Avoid using words such as “aggressive,” “dangerous,” or “bad” which may anger pet owners and not accurately describe the animal.
- Related **Mass Care Groups Standards**
  - Initiating Mass Care Services
  - Prioritizing Mass Care Services
  - Mass Care Service Site Requirements
- Related **Sheltering Activity Standards**
  - Shelter Safety and Client Standards
  - Household Pets and Service Animals

What to do

Supporting a pet owner who is struggling to care for their pet

- If a client is struggling to take care of their pet, talk with them to determine what challenges they are facing and what might help them.
- If a pet appears distressed (example behaviors: excessive barking, licking, or moving) inform the animal welfare partner.
- Support the owner in a sensitive and compassionate way.
  - As needed, coordinate with *Disaster Health Services* or *Disaster Mental Health Services* sections to explore the challenges and potential solutions.
  - Work with animal welfare partner to explore how they can support the pet and its owner.

Supporting sick and injured pets

- If you notice or a client informs you that their pet is sick or injured, immediately seek support from the animal welfare partner (with owner’s consent).
- If no animal welfare partner is present at shelter, refer the client to an emergency veterinary resource provided by the animal welfare partner or the *HQ Pet Shelter Services Coordinator.*
- If no veterinary partner has been identified, work with *External Relations section* to identify one.

Responding to animal fights

- If a pet attacks another pet, immediately instruct the owners to separate the pets and move with their pet in opposite directions, preferably out of the view of the other animal(s).
- The Shelter Site Manager must speak with both pet owners and reinforce pet policies.
- When both pets are injured in the fight support the owners with finding prompt veterinary care.

- When only one animal is injured, support the owner in seeking veterinary care for the injured pet and isolate the other animal.
    - Seek and follow veterinarian and/or animal welfare partner guidance to support the uninjured animal.

- Record the incident in SCIA by recording the details as a comment in SCIA.
- Make any additional referrals that the client needs.
    - For example: the owners may want or need a referral to talk with Disaster Mental Health and/or Disaster Spiritual Care

Pet bites a person at the shelter

- Immediately isolate the animal by placing it in a crate provided by owner or the animal welfare partner.
- Promptly request assistance from Emergency Medical Services or Disaster Health Services to address injury.
    - If the bite is serious the injured individual should seek prompt medical attention (hospital or urgent care center).

- Confirm the status of the pet's rabies vaccination.
- Notifications and documentation
    - Shelter Site Manager must document the incident in the Shelter Manager Log and completes any animal bite forms required by local/state government.
    - The Shelter Site Manager or HQ Pet Shelter Services Coordinator must contact the Agency Having Jurisdiction (AHJ) and the Disaster Health Services HQ Manager the local Health Department to report bite.
    - Shelter Site Manager and/or Pet Services Field Team member notify the HQ Sheltering Manager and the HQ Pet Shelter Services Coordinator of the incident.

- Shelter staff follow directions provided by the animal Agency Having Jurisdiction (AHJ) and/or Health Department.
    - The local Agency Having Jurisdiction (AHJ) works directly with this pet owner to inform them of any next steps.

Pet Surrenders/Relinquish Ownership

- If a household states they wish/need to surrender or relinquish ownership of their pet be compassionate and kind.
- Inform the animal welfare partner, the HQ Pet Services Coordinator and HQ Sheltering Manager, who can explore alternatives to prevent surrender.
    - Immediate action must be taken if owner is no longer at shelter and has abandoned animal by informing the animal welfare partner immediately.

- No member of the Red Cross workforce is to take custody of a pet.
- Any interest in adoption or fostering must be coordinated with the Animal Welfare Partner.

Related Articles

Pet Shelter Services Intent
Executive/High-Level Overview of the Pet Shelter Services which provides support to households with pets that are checked into Red Cross shelters.

Pet Sheltering Requirements
Physical requirements and procedures for co-located and cohabitated pet sheltering

Sheltering Toolkit
Resources for Red Cross workers supporting the sheltering activity during readiness and shelter operations

Questions

Safety in Shelters / Emergency Action Plan Job Tool

Disaster Cycle Services Job Tools

Respond / Sheltering

Maintaining the safety of clients and workforce in shelters is an essential responsibility of all shelter workers. Each shelter should have an emergency plan and post an evacuation plan and maps showing assembly points outside the building. The evacuation plan and maps should be posted within 24 hours of opening. The *Shelter Emergency Action Plan* should be completed within 48 to 72 hours of opening. The plan should be emailed to the HQ Life Safety & Asset Protection (LSAP) Coordinator or HQ Logistics Manager when it is completed.

LSAP and/or Logistics/Facilities normally conduct basic safety inspections prior to opening a shelter, and LSAP conducts site visits in larger DROs to ensure continued safety and compliance with the *Shelter Emergency Action Plan*.

The Shelter Site Manager is responsible for emergency planning but may appoint a Shelter Emergency Readiness Leader to create the emergency plan, post an evacuation plan, and identify assembly points, monitor internal and external risks, and take steps to ensure safety. This task is delegated to a shelter worker in addition to their duties, rather than a individual being dedicated to the task.

External Risks

These risks from outside the shelter facility include heavy snow or water buildup on roofs, high winds and tornados, rising floodwaters, or approaching wildfires. These risks may endanger the facility and its clients and staff or may create conditions that isolate the shelter by cutting off roadways and communications. External risks may require immediate roof clearing, moving clients to a safer part of the facility, or evacuation to another facility.

Internal Risks

Risks inside the facility include wet floors, cracks or holes in floors that can cause falls and injuries, exposed electrical wire, damage to the facility that could cause injuries, and outbreaks of infectious diseases. The potential for fire, the absence of appropriate fire extinguishers, and blocked aisles and exits also create significant risks. While highly unlikely, there is also a possibility of an active shooter situation.

Action Items for Shelter Site Manager/ Shelter Emergency Readiness Leader

- ☐ Check that basic safety checks are occurring at the beginning of each shift as part of the shift inspection. That the *Shelter Shift Inspection Form* is kept in the *Shelter Log;*
- ☐ Mark and tape off any internal risks or hazards found and report them to the HQ LSAP Coordinator or HQ Logistics Manager to remedy. Follow up if necessary;
- ☐ Request a threat assessment from the HQ LSAP Coordinator and law enforcement in complex shelters;

- ☐ Identify disaster-related threats and monitor them to ensure changes do not threaten the safety of the shelter and its clients and staff;
- ☐ Prepare and maintain a *Shelter Emergency Action Plan*;
- ☐ Add shelter specific information to the attached *Shelter Emergency Action Plan;*
- ☐ Provide copies to the Shelter Site Manager, Shelter Shift Supervisors, Shelter Dormitory Supervisor(s) and Shelter Registration Supervisor, and email to the HQ LSAP Coordinator or HQ Logistics Manager;
- ☐ Brief the Shelter Site Manager, Shift Supervisors, and staff from all shifts on the plan and actions they may need to take. Repeat this briefing weekly as a reminder and to account for staff turnover.



Shelter Emergency Action Plan

Name of Shelter *[_____]*

Street Location *[_____]*

DR # *[_____]*

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Purpose

This plan has been prepared by the Shelter Emergency Readiness Leader in preparation for potential significant threats to the shelter, its clients and its staff. Its purpose is to guide and coordinate actions required in the event of an emergency.

Plans for dealing with emergencies are listed below and are augmented for the specifics of the shelter facility. This document is based on American Red Cross Risk Management, Federal Emergency Management Agency (FEMA), and National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration (NOAA) guidance for emergencies.

Emergency Evacuation for Fire, Gas Leak or Other Danger

The shelter may need to be evacuated for any number of reasons, including a gas leak and fire within the shelter.

The determination to make an emergency evacuation is made by the Shelter Site Manager or the Shift Supervisor in the absence of the Shelter Site Manager. Evacuation should be made as soon as alarms or visible signs of the threat exist.

Preparedness (Action Required by Shelter Emergency Readiness Leader)

As soon a feasible after shelter opening, the safety officer should determine evacuation routes and the assembly point outside the shelter, prepare and prominently post a drawing of the shelter indicating the evacuation routes and outside assembly point throughout the dormitory and shelter site. **The evacuation routes and assembly point drawing should be stapled to the back of this plan.**

In many cases and evacuation plan may already be prepared and posted in the shelter facility. If one exists, it should be used and minor adjustments to account for closed off areas of the shelter site and any additional assembly places required.

Evacuation Process (Action Required by Shelter Site Manager and Workforce)

- ☐ Immediately dial 911 and report the emergency.
- ☐ Make a calm announcement telling residents them to leave personal belongings behind, and directing them to **walk not run** to the evacuation routes and assembly point.
- ☐ Shelter supervisors and workforce should be directed to disperse to specific locations to direct clients to the evacuation routes and assembly point. If heat is felt or smoke visible at an exit, direct clients to another route.
- ☐ Shelter workers should be assigned to assist clients with functional and access needs.

- ☐ A staff member should collect the client registration form book or folder and take it with them.
- ☐ The Shelter Site Manager or Supervisors should make a walk through the facility to ensure all residents and staff are evacuated.
- ☐ Inform the HQ Sheltering Manager/District Sheltering Coordinator that the shelter has been evacuated.
- ☐ Inform the HQ Life Safety & Asset Protection (LSAP) Coordinator or HQ Logistics Manager that the shelter has been evacuated.
- ☐ Once at the evacuation point, clients should be calmed and made as comfortable as possible.
- ☐ A check of clients present against the registration forms and compile a list of missing individual compiled. Do the same for workforce and visitors using sign-in sheets.
- ☐ The Shelter Site Manager or the Shift Supervisor in the absence of the Shelter Site Manager should liaise with emergency personnel arriving to the scene until Life Safety & Asset Protection arrives and takes over that function.
- ☐ No one should be allowed to return to the shelter until emergency personnel and LSAP deem it safe.

Power Outage

Electrical power is important for lighting, refrigeration, heating/cooling equipment, medical devices, and computers and phones used in shelters.

Power outages regularly occur during disasters and can affect shelters with short- or longer-term power losses unless the shelter is served by backup generators.

Preparedness (Action Required by Shelter Emergency Readiness Leader)

Determine if the facility has a backup power generator and whether it switches on automatically or must be turned on and off manually and who should be contacted from the facility in the event of power outage.

Facility contact for this shelter is [_____]

Actions during Power Outages (Action Required by Shelter Site Manager and Workforce)

- ☐ Only use flashlights and battery powered lanterns for emergency lighting. Do not use candles because they can cause fires.
- ☐ Inform the HQ Sheltering Manager/District Sheltering Coordinator that power has been lost and ask them to inform the HQ LSAP Coordinator and HQ Logistics Manager.
- ☐ Check on all clients with electrical medical devices to ensure they have battery power.

- ☐ Keep refrigerator and freezer doors closed. Most food or medicine requiring refrigeration can be kept safely in a closed refrigerator for several hours. An unopened refrigerator will keep food cold for about 4 hours. A full freezer will keep the temperature for about 48 hours.
- ☐ Turn off or disconnect appliances and other equipment in case of a momentary power "surge" that can damage computers and other devices. Consider adding surge protectors.
- ☐ Monitor clients and workforce for cold or warm if the outage is prolonged and take necessary steps to improve comfort.

Tornados

Tornadoes can create significant loss of life and damage at a shelter so extreme care must be exercised in the event of tornado watches and warnings. Large areas used for shelters, such as gymnasiums, are vulnerable so clients may need to be moved within the facility for safety.

Preparedness (Action Required by Shelter Emergency Readiness Leader)

The safety officer should identify the safest location within the facility that clients and staff can be moved in the event of a tornado. Many facilities may already have designated spaces, but if they do not the best locations are normally windowless interior hallway in a basement, bathrooms or a hallway on the first floor if necessary.

The tornado safety location for this shelter is: [_____]

Tornado Watch (Action Required by Shelter Emergency Readiness Leader)

It is not necessary to move clients and staff to the safe area in the event of tornado watch. These indicate that weather conditions make tornados possible and that one should be prepared to act.

Whenever a tornado watch is issued for the area of the shelter, the safety officer or a designated person should monitor the battery-operated NOAA Weather Radio and local media for updates changes to a tornado warning.

Tornado Warning (Action Required by Shelter Site Manager and Workforce)

A tornado warning indicates a tornado has been sighted physically or by electronic monitoring and that protective action should be taken immediately.

- ☐ Make a calm announcement telling residents to leave personal belongings behind, and directing them to **walk not run** to the predetermined safety location.
- ☐ Shelter supervisors and staff should be directed to disperse to specific locations to direct clients to the predetermined safety area.
- ☐ Shelter workers should be assigned to assist clients with functional and access needs.
- ☐ Make clients as comfortable as possible.
- ☐ Inform the HQ Sheltering Manager/District Sheltering Coordinator that clients and staff are taking refuge in the predetermined safety area; Ask that the HQ LSAP Coordinator and HQ Logistics Manager be informed.
- ☐ A staff member should collect the client registration form book or folder and take it with them.
- ☐ Check clients present against the registration forms and compile a list of missing individuals.
- ☐ The Shelter Site Manager or Supervisors should make a walk through the facility to ensure all residents and staff are out of the danger zones.
- ☐ No one should be allowed to return to other areas of the shelter until the tornado warning is lifted.

Severe Thunderstorm and Lightning

Strong winds and electrical storms can create significant damage and potential for loss of life in a shelter, particularly from falling trees and electrical shock.

Storm Warning (Action Required by Shelter Emergency Readiness Leader)

When a storm warning is issued, the Safety Office should monitor the situation using a battery-operated NOAA Weather Radio and local media for updates.

Storm Over Shelter (Action Required by Shelter Site Manager and Workforce)

If the storm reaches the shelter, an announcement should be made telling clients and staff to:

- ☐ Avoid contact with corded phones and other devices including those plugged into electric for recharging. Cordless and wireless phones not connected to wall outlets are OK to use.
- ☐ Avoid contact with electrical equipment or cords. Unplug appliances and other electrical items such as computers and turn off air conditioners.
- ☐ Avoid contact with plumbing. Plumbing and bathroom fixtures can conduct electricity.
- ☐ Stay away from windows and doors, and inside.
- ☐ Do not lie on concrete floors or lean against concrete walls because shockwave can cause injury.
- ☐ Staff should move among the clients comforting and reassuring them.

- ☐ Make an announcement when the storm watch is lifted, and normal activity can resume.

Approaching Flood Waters or Wildfire

Approaching flood waters or wildfires should be carefully monitored and the HQ Sheltering Manager/District Sheltering Coordinator immediately informed, and advice sought. Efforts will be made to move the shelter, clients and workforce.

If the threat is imminent and immediate evacuation is required, the shelter leadership should:

- ☐ Prepare to evacuate to the safest location possible in the area. This may not be designated assembly points.
- ☐ Ask on-site law enforcement, fire or emergency management officials for guidance.
- ☐ Determine the safest route to for clients and workforce to walk to safety.
- ☐ Make calm announcements organizing the clients. Move them out of the shelter and toward safety.
- ☐ Inform the HQ Sheltering Manager/District Sheltering Coordinator you are evacuating the shelter; Ask that the HQ LSAP Coordinator and HQ Logistics Manager be informed.
- ☐ Designate shelter workers to help anyone needing assistance.
- ☐ Registration workers should take the registration forms/books with them when they leave.
- ☐ Shelter Site Manager should take shelter logs and confidential records.
- ☐ A check of clients present against the registration forms should be made and a list of missing individuals compiled as soon as possible at the safe location.

Earthquake

Earthquakes, a sudden shaking caused by rocks shifting underneath the earth's surface, occur regularly without harming individuals or causing serious damage. Larger and sustained earthquakes have the potential to create significant damage and loss of life. They can damage structures and roads and cause fires, landslides, avalanches, and tsunamis. Aftershocks can be expected following a major earthquake and these can create additional damage.

The immediate dangers in shelters during earthquakes are from falling items or building collapse. Large open rooms such as shelter dormitories are vulnerable in strong earthquakes and little protection exists for individuals in them because there is little furniture under which to seek protection.

Preparedness (Action Required by Shelter Emergency Readiness Leader)

The primary preparedness task is to regularly check that that supplies, equipment and other materials are not stacked in a way that could fall on residents and staff during an earthquake and that the general evacuation plan is in place and posted throughout the shelter.

During an Earthquake (Action Required by Shelter Site Manager and Workforce)

During a strong quake make an announcement if possible that residents and staff should drop to the ground and protect their heads and necks with their arms.

After an Earthquake (Action Required by Shelter Site Manager and Workforce)

- ☐ Check clients and workforce for injuries and provide first aid if necessary. Call 911 for significant injuries.
- ☐ Check the shelter for damage. If it is damaged, evacuate the building and stay a safe distance from the structure and power lines.
- ☐ Contact the HQ Sheltering Manager/District Sheltering Coordinator and report your situation; ask that the HQ Logistics Manager be informed.
- ☐ If you are in an area that may experience tsunamis, move clients and staff inland or to higher ground immediately.
- ☐ The Shelter Emergency Readiness Leader should monitor local news reports for emergency information and instructions via battery operated radio, TV, social media, or from cell phone text alerts.

Bomb Threat / Suspicious Package (Action Required by Shelter Site Manager and Workforce)

In the event of a bomb threat against the facility, or concerns a suspicious package may be a bomb, take the following steps:

- ☐ Do NOT use two-way radios or cellular phones in the vicinity of a suspicious package; radio signals have the potential to detonate a bomb.
- ☐ Call 911 and report the bomb threat/suspicious package providing as much detail as you can.
- ☐ Follow law enforcement instructions.
- ☐ Do NOT approach or inspect suspicious items or unattended packages.
- ☐ Evacuate the area and seek protective cover from the bomb and potential debris.
- ☐ Contact the HQ Sheltering Manager/District Sheltering Coordinator and report your situation; Ask that the HQ LSAP Coordinator and HQ Logistics Manager be informed.

Hostile Intruder/Active Shooter (Action Required by Shelter Site Manager and Workforce)

In the event of a hostile intruder or active shooter, the primary task of shelter workers is to protect residents in the shelter dormitory and themselves. Dial 911 immediately. inform them of a hostile intruder/active shooter situation. Be prepared to provide the following:

- ☐ Number and description of shooter(s).
- ☐ Location of the shooter(s).
- ☐ Type of weapon if known (e.g., handgun, rifle).
- ☐ Stay on the line to provide updates.
- ☐ Have another shelter worker contact the HQ Sheltering Manager/District Sheltering Coordinator and report your situation as soon as possible; Ask that the HQ LSAP Coordinator and HQ Logistics Manager be informed.

Hostile Intruder/Active Shooter OUTSIDE the Facility (Action Required by Shelter Site Manager and Worker)

When hostile intruder/active shooter is outside the facility, the primary objective is to keep them from entering the shelter and from harming residents and staff from outside.

- ☐ Remain inside.
- ☐ The Shelter Site Manager or Shift Supervisor should order the immediate lockdown of the facility. Staff should close and lock all exterior windows and doors.
- ☐ Alert everyone inside the facility about the situation.
- ☐ Cover windows and try to get everyone down so that no one is visible from outside the facility.
- ☐ Call 9-1-1 and stay on the line with the dispatcher and provide your name; location and location of the incident; and number and identification of the shooters.
- ☐ Stay in place until the all-clear is given by law enforcement personnel.

Hostile Intruder/Active Shooter INSIDE the Facility (Action Required by Shelter Site Manager and Workforce)

If the hostile intruder or Active Shooter is inside the facility, the primary objective is to keep as many clients, staff, and visitor safe by helping them escape, restricting access to them, or attacking the hostile intruder/active shooter if there is no other option.

Assess the Situation. Determine the most reasonable way to protect your own life. Clients and visitors are most likely to follow the lead of Red Cross personnel during a hostile intruder/active shooter situation.

Determine the location of the shooter. TAKE IMMEDIATE ACTION in the method safest possible for you and clients.

Evacuate

If there is an accessible escape path, attempt to evacuate the premises.

- ☐ If the shooter is in the dormitory, staff should direct clients to flee through exits.
- ☐ Run away from the sound of shooting; put as much distance between you and the shooter as possible. Leave your belongings behind.
- ☐ Help others escape whenever possible.
- ☐ Call 9-1-1 when it is safe to do so.
- ☐ Warn others not to enter the area where the shooter may be.
- ☐ Do not attempt to move wounded people.
- ☐ Keep your hands visible.
- ☐ Follow the instructions of law enforcement.
- ☐ Go to the outside evacuation assembly point if safe. Do not leave the safe location or assembly point until instructed to do so by law enforcement.

Shelter in Place/Hide

If evacuation is not possible and the shooter is in other parts of the facility, staff members should close and barricade the dormitory door(s) with heavy furniture and items. In other parts of the facility, find a place to hide where the shooter is less likely to find you.

- ☐ Everyone should stay hidden and away from windows and exterior doors.
- ☐ Stay out of the shooter's view.
- ☐ Do not trap yourself or restrict your options from movement.
- ☐ Hide behind any large items (e.g., cabinets, desks).
- ☐ Silence your cell phone or pager.
- ☐ Remain quiet.
- ☐ Not come out until advised otherwise by law enforcement.

Attack the Hostile Intruder/Active Shooter

As a last resort and only when your life is in imminent danger, attempt to disrupt and/or incapacitate the shooter by:

- ☐ Acting as aggressively as possible to incapacitate him/her.
- ☐ Throwing items and using improvised weapons.
- ☐ Yelling and committing to your actions.

Infectious Disease Outbreak (Action Required by Shelter Site Manager and Shelter Emergency Readiness Leader and Disaster Health Services)

Infectious disease outbreak or threat will normally be brought to the attention of the shelter leadership by Disaster Health Services, a Public Health Agency or the HQ Sheltering

Manager/District Sheltering Coordinator. This may include infections such as influenza, Norovirus, or COVID-19.

- ☐ Ask for immediate guidance on how shelter operations should be altered.
- ☐ Inform the HQ Sheltering Manager/District Sheltering Coordinator if the information came from other parties.
- ☐ Contact the HQ Logistics/Facilities Coordinator if specialized cleaning is needed.
- ☐ Obtain specific job tools for the type of infection from The Exchange.
- ☐ Plan and institute protective measures advised by health authorities and job tools.
- ☐ Begin identifying and planning for an Isolation Care Area.

Evacuation Routes Drawing with Assembly Point(s) [Attach copy here]

Serving Clients Legally Required to Register with Government Agencies

Guidance for workers on how to lawfully and discreetly support individuals required to register with government agencies during disasters.

Typically performed by: *Shelter Site Manager*
Roles likely to support task: *HQ Sheltering Manager, Mass Care Chief, AD Operations*

Considerations

- Like all individuals affected by the disaster, individuals required to register with government agencies must be provided shelter during disasters.
- Those required to register with government agencies may include:
    - Individuals on bail, bond, probation
    - Those with certain communicable diseases
    - Sex offenders

- How and where these persons are sheltered depends on state and local law and the level of potential risk that they pose to others.
- Red Cross procedure balances:
    - Red Cross nondiscriminatory humanitarian mission
    - State and local law
    - The need to safeguard all clients in shelters

    - The unique legal status of persons required to register with authorities
- When the laws of the jurisdiction do not allow an individual to be housed at the shelter, the local government must provide alternative shelter.
- These individuals at a shelter may create additional strain on an already traumatized population. The Shelter Site Manager must handle the situation discretely and may need to provide some separation between the individual(s) and the general population.
- Related **Shelter Activity Standards**:
    - Shelter Operations
    - Shelter Safety and Client Standard

What to do

Seek Guidance as needed

- Shelter Site Managers should request guidance from the HQ Sheltering Manager when they are uncertain of how to handle a client who discloses they must register.

Prepare registration workers

- The Red Cross does not directly ask each person arriving at a shelter if they must register with government, although a sign with the following language may be posted on the registration desk:
    - "*Please inform the registration worker if someone in your household is required by law to register with a state or local government agency for any reason*."

- The Shelter Site Manager ensures all shelter workers, especially those working in the reception and registration areas, know that there are multiple reasons individuals must disclose that they are required by law to register with a state or local government agency.
- The Shelter Site Manager ensures reception/registration workers are trained to discreetly refer these individuals to

the Shelter Site Manager.

Protect privacy of clients who must register with governmental agencies

- The Shelter Site Manager's is responsible for protecting the privacy of these individuals while also protecting other shelter residents.
- Shelter Manager meets privately with those required to register
    - Meet in a private location with this client so that conversations and interactions are confidential and preserve the dignity of the client.

- Determine next actions.
    - **If the client indicates registration is required because of a communicable disease,** refer them to Disaster Health Services who will determine if an alternative sheltering solution should be provided.
    - I**f the client indicates registration is required because of bail, bond, or probation conditions**, the Shelter Site Manager should ensure the client understands shelter rules, advise them to contact their probation officer or point of contact as soon as possible, and return with them to the registration desk to continue registering.
        - Clients in this category should be treated as any other resident in the shelter, but their behavior may be watched more carefully.

    - **If the client indicates they are a sex offender**, advise the client that Red Cross policy requires the notification of local law enforcement to determine whether the client can remain in the shelter.
        - If the client chooses to remain, ask them to confine their activities to a specific area at the shelter that is separate from the general shelter population and under the observation

of a Red Cross worker until law enforcement arrives at the shelter or advises the next steps.
    - The Shelter Site Manager speaks privately with law enforcement upon arrival and provides pertinent information. Law enforcement speaks with the client and, if required, conducts a check into the client's background.
    - If the law permits the registered sex offender to remain in the shelter, the Shelter Site Manager notifies shelter security personnel present in the shelter and the HQ Sheltering Manager.

Collaborate with governmental agencies

- The HQ Sheltering Manager provides Shelter Site Managers with information about local laws regarding sheltering services to sex offenders and others required to register and about any procedures in the local jurisdiction should be followed.
- The Shelter Site Manager must collaborate with law enforcement (whether they are supporting at the shelter or off-site) and ensure appropriate procedures are established and followed.
    - The Shelter Site Manager records appropriate information in the client's record in SCIA as a comment.
    - The registered client should stay in an area where they can be monitored appropriately. Any conversation about this client with staff and appropriate authorities are kept to a minimum and only when necessary to protect safety and privacy.
    - If the client cannot remain in the shelter, law enforcement must collaborate with Red Cross to identify an alternate shelter.

Handling reports of clients suspected to be required to register but did not self-report

Other clients in a shelter may report that a person is present who they believe is required to register with the with government or who they believe may be on a sex offender registry.

- This is common in smaller communities where other clients or law enforcement may recognize a client required to register.
- This can result in a direct confrontation or a report to shelter staff. If this occurs, workers should immediately notify the Shelter Site Manager.
- In these situations:
    - The Shelter Site Manager speaks with the client to understand the situation.
    - To protect the safety of other clients and individuals.
        - A client who are is sex offender; they are escorted to a safe area designated by the Shelter Site Manager.
        - A Red Cross volunteer or employee monitors the client to ensure other clients do not encounter the isolated client.
    - The Shelter Site Manager immediately notifies law enforcement and the HQ Sheltering Manager.

Related Articles

Sheltering Toolkit
Resources for Red Cross workers supporting the sheltering activity during readiness and shelter operations

Creating a Client-First Sheltering Environment
Steps for workers in shelters are to build a climate of putting clients first

Posting Signage at Shelters
Instructions for posting signs at key shelter locations to provide information for clients and workers

Maintaining Safety and Health in Shelters

USEFUL SHELTERING INFORMATION (8/3/26)

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Storing Client Belongings

Guidance for caring for client belongings at shelter sites

Typically performed by: Shelter Site Manager
Roles likely to support task: HQ Sheltering Manager, Mass Care Chief, Shelter Shift Supervisors, AD Logistics

Considerations

- Clients often arrive at evacuation and emergency shelters with their belongings during a disaster. The volume of possessions is likely to depend on how much evacuation warning was provided.
- Shelter managers and staff support clients in caring for their belongings during their stay at the shelter.
- Storing client belongings within the dormitory creates challenges with space, security, safety, and access. To avoid these issues, what a client may bring into the dormitory is typically limited to what they can fit under their cot.
- In some cases, it may be necessary to provide limited storage space at the shelter for additional belongings.
- Related **Shelter Activity Standards:**
  - Shelter Operations
  - Household Pets and Service Animals
  - Shelter Safety and Client Standards

What to do

Choose storage options to be used

Under Cot Storage

- Logistics can obtain under-cot storage boxes or alternative (one per cot) for those who need them.

Storage Outside the Shelter

- Storage of personal belongings outside the shelter facility is preferrable.
- Client's store possession in their private vehicles located outside the shelter.
- Clients may keep their belongings in personal utility trailers in the shelter parking lot when there is enough space.
- Personal belongings should NOT be stored in tents or under tarps outside the shelter as they are unsecure and may become wet, moldy or smoky and unusable or a health hazard.

Indoor Storage within the Shelter Facility

- During the opening inspection, the Shelter Site Manager identifies a secured indoor area suitable for storage of client belongings.
    - This should be a locked room or storage area.
    - Establish an agreement and procedure for storage with the facility manager.

Secured Outdoor Storage

- In situations where indoor storage is not available, consider requesting a lockable shipping container or box truck to provide storage space outside the shelter.
- The Shelter Site Manager discusses such a need for HQ Sheltering Manager, who can make a request to Logistics.
- When such storage is provided, follow the directions for managing Red Cross provided storage.

Establish storage area space and identify resources needed for storage

- Determine the maximum storage space allocation per client by dividing the square footage of the storage area by the projected number of clients requiring storage.
- Determine what types of items can be stored by clients (for example: suitcases, foot lockers, boxes, baby strollers, and bicycles etc.) and post this information where all clients can view.
    - Do not allow storage of items such as open food containers, drugs, weapons, and flammable or other dangerous material.

- If the storage area is large, the Shelter Site Manager creates a floor plan to organize stored goods for easier recovery.
    - Use painter's tape to mark space allocation and walk-ways.
    - Use an alphabetic system, marking areas with letters (for storage by last name) or a numbering system with areas marked by numbers or if large enough, use alpha-numeric system (like A1, B2).

- If needed, the Shelter Site Manager should request 20- to 50-gallon plastic totes from Logistics and determine how many to allocate to each household with belongings to store (like 4 per household or 2 per client).

Identify Space and Resources Needed for Storage

- Develop a shelter specific storage plan that outlines procedures for clients to access their belongings that are in the storage location.
- Label each stored item (container, box, bag, bicycle, etc.) with the client's full name and contact information including cell phone number.
- Record details of items that clients place in the storage area as a comment in the client record in SCIA.

Control Access to Storage Area

- A Red Cross worker must always accompany clients when accessing the storage area.
- Only one client along with a Red Cross worker is allowed to access the storage area at a time.
- The Red Cross worker confirms that the client accesses only their belongings by asking for ID.
- Provide the client a reasonable amount of privacy while still maintaining security.

Control Access to Storage Area

Suspected Prohibited Items

- When it is suspected that a storage container has prohibited items, the Shelter Site Manager contacts the Sheltering Activity Manager and onsite security.
- A Shift Supervisor or Shelter Site Manager, along with onsite security, conducts and documents an inspection conducted with the client present unless client has left the shelter.
    - Use disposable gloves during the inspection. Safety gloves or double gloves are recommended to protect against needles or other sharp objects.

Abandoned Items

- If client abandons or appears to have abandoned stored items:
    - Call the client at their contact number and place a time limit for picking up items.
    - Document the contact as a comment in the client's record in SCIA.
    - If the client is unreachable, a Shift Supervisor and a second Red Cross worker open, inspect, and inventory the contents to prepare it for disposal.

- If the client does not retrieve their belongings by the deadline:
    - Take photos of the stored items with the name visible before opening the container.

- Provide the inventory with photos to the Shelter Site Manager for inclusion in the Manager's Log.
- Relocate the container to a designed holding area for final disposition.

Related Articles

Sharing Key Information Between the Shelter and the HQ Sheltering Manager
Types of information and methods of communication shared between shelters and DRO headquarters.

Determining Shelter Layout
Details on effectively establishing a physical organization of a shelter site in order to deliver services to standards

Creating a Client-First Sheltering Environment
Steps for workers in shelters are to build a climate of putting clients first

Posting Signage at Shelters
Instructions for posting signs at key shelter locations to provide information for clients and workers

Sheltering Toolkit
Resources for Red Cross workers supporting the sheltering activity during readiness and shelter operations

Mass Care Toolkit
Overview of Mass Care guidance and resources with links to more specific information

Questions

For assistance contact **Sheltering@redcross.org**

Storing Client Belongings v1 2026.04.28 Mass Care / Sheltering

Does this page require a review? Click the link below to inform the author.

Report Content To Author

Supporting Accessibility at Shelters

Guidance for workers at shelters on providing accessible services to all clients

Typically performed by: Shelter Site Manager
Roles likely to support task: Shelter Shift Supervisors, Disaster Disability Integration, Disaster Health Services

Considerations

- We provide accessible services to all clients including people with disabilities and other access and functional needs.
- We prioritize making necessary accommodations and modifications to make all areas and services of the shelter accessible.
- Related **Shelter Activity Standards**:
    - Shelter Operations

What to do

- Ask clients if there is anything specific that Red Cross can do to support them while they are staying at the shelter.
    - Do not assume what help is needed.

- Consult with Disaster Disability Integration and Disaster Health Services to for guidance to determine the appropriate accommodation or modification to meet client accessibility needs.
- Make sure the areas being used for client services are accessible to all clients and workers and be sure the following areas are accessible to all clients and workers:
    - Shelter parking and drop-off areas
    - Entrances and exits
    - Restrooms and showers
    - Routes within the shelter
    - Sleeping areas
    - Feeding areas
    - Supply distribution areas

- Inform HQ Sheltering Manager if modifications are needed. This might include ramps, railing, or additional lighting.
    - Make sure clients who require electrical power for medical equipment have access and facilitate use if needed.

- When needed, arrange for mobility equipment.
    - Request equipment from Disaster Health Services or Fulfillment if a client needs a wheelchair, walker, or other mobility support.

- Post accessible signage throughout the shelter.
    - Post universal signage and large-print signage for those who are visually impaired
    - Use multiple language signage and signs with images/graphics when possible
    - Coordinate with DRO Headquarters when signage in Braille or other languages is necessary

- Supporting clients whose primary language is not English.
    - Ensure announcements and posted information are available in all primary languages of clients at the shelter.
    - Share information in multiple languages, according to the needs of the clients and staff

    - If phone-based or in-person spoken language translation services are needed, submit the request to the Sheltering Activity Manager
- Supporting clients who may have difficulty reading.
    - Recruit volunteers to read information for clients who can't read.
    - Make large-print signs in at least 18-point font with high contrast black text on white background for clients with reduced vision.

- Supporting clients who are deaf or hard of hearing.
    - Activate the closed captioning function on all televisions.
    - Make audio announcements available in writing out or by using sign language interpreters when needed.
    - Offer Video Relay Services for client needing to make calls.
    - For more, see the Video Relay Services for Deaf or Hard of Hearing clients Job Tool
    - Provide access to sign language interpreters and/or Video Remote Interpreting services for Deaf or Hard of Hearing clients who use sign language.

Related Articles

Sheltering Toolkit
Resources for Red Cross workers supporting the sheltering activity during readiness and shelter operations

Creating a Client-First Sheltering Environment
Steps for workers in shelters are to build a climate of putting clients first

Sharing Key Information Between the Shelter and the HQ Sheltering Manager
Types of information and methods of communication shared between shelters and DRO headquarters.

Gather and Share Essential Information to Support the Initiation of Sheltering

Welcoming and Supporting Partners Working at a Shelter

Guidance for orienting and engaging direct support from partners at shelters

Typically performed by: *Shelter Site Manager, Shelter Shift Supervisor*
Roles likely to support task: *Shelter Resident Transition, Client Care, HQ Sheltering Manager*

Considerations

- Operational leadership coordinates and approves the assignment of partner organizations to support operations and our clients at Red Cross Managed shelters.
- The needs of clients and the shelter site will influence the types of services and levels of support that partners would provide at shelters.
- Partner organizations that may support shelter operations include animal welfare agencies, county social services, feeding partners, homeless service agencies and children's services.
- The types of activities and support the partner provides influence how much space and equipment they need at the shelter.
- Organizations supporting Red Cross operations must act in ways that align with Red Cross principles and policies and work under the oversight of the Shelter Site Manager.

- Partners access to individual client information must be coordinate with Operational Leadership – as opposed to the shelter staff -- to determine what information will be provided and if an information sharing agreement is needed.
- Related **Shelter Activity Standards**:
    - Shelter Operations

What to do

- Welcome the partner and identify their leader.
- Be sure you understand of their mission and desired approach to supporting clients and/or the shelter operation.
- Provide an orientation to the current operations and activities of the shelter.
- Provide an overview of the client population and identified needs.
- Determine the location where they will work and provide workspace, internet access and other logistical support as appropriate.
- The Shelter Site Manager checks-in daily (or with greater frequency when necessary) to discuss any needs and share information.
- Include partners in daily shelter briefings.
- If another organization arrives at the shelter without the shelter staff receiving notification that they will be coming, immediately contact the HQ Sheltering Manager to discuss how that organization will be supporting shelter operations.

Related Articles

Responding to Conflict and Difficult Client Situations in a Shelter
Guidance for workers in shelters on approaches to addressing challenging situations related to clients

Sheltering Toolkit
Resources for Red Cross workers supporting the sheltering activity during readiness and shelter operations

Questions

For assistance contact **Sheltering@redcross.org**

Welcoming and Supporting Partners Working at a Shelter V1 2026.04.28

Mass Care - Sheltering

Does this page require a review? Click the link below to inform the author.

Report Content To Author

What to Expect on the Job: First-Time Congregate Shelter Service Worker Tasks

Taking care of people affected by disaster is the primary activity of the American Red Cross during a disaster response. We are happy to have you come help the Red Cross by serving people staying in a shelter, our "clients."

A "congregate shelter" is a group shelter located in a school, community center, church, or other suitable location where people affected by disaster stay as part of an evacuation or as they begin their recovery. People staying in a shelter come from all walks of life, with differing ages, income levels, health issues, cultures, and/or dietary requirements. Some may have experienced life challenges prior to this disaster, like domestic violence, precarious housing situations, or being on parole.

No matter the circumstance, the Red Cross is committed to treating everyone with dignity and respect and meeting individual needs while in the shelter. During your work in the shelter, please interact with everyone staying in the shelter with equal compassion and kindness.

Shelter workers carry out many tasks. This job tool gives some basic information about these tasks to get you started. Your supervisor is here to give directions and answer questions.

PREPARE FOR YOUR SHIFT

Before heading out for your shift, please review the following checklist to make sure you are ready:

- ☐ Log into Volunteer Connection and watch the *Everyone is Welcome* (45 min) training video if you did not view it as part of your training.
- ☐ Bring personal identification.
- ☐ Wear close-toed comfortable shoes and dress appropriately for conditions. (You may be walking a lot through the facility and many congregate shelters can be relatively cold so bring a sweater.) Do not wear shirts with slogans or large branding logos on them.
- ☐ If you are not feeling well such as a sore throat, temperature or exhaustion please contact staff health to determine whether you should report to your shift.
- ☐ Consider bringing your own mask, pen, pad of paper, smart phone, and charger.
- ☐ Bring any medications that you will need during your shift.
- ☐ Red Cross is committed to providing a safe and welcoming environment.
    - Harassment, threats, or violence of any kind is not tolerated.
    - One of our core values is *neutrality*. Please be respectful of religious, political, and other beliefs that clients and fellow workers may hold. Avoid discussing these sensitive topics.
    - The Red Cross must be respectful of the confidentiality of the people we serve. For this reason, do not post images or comments on social media.

LIST OF TASKS

Shelter workers do all tasks necessary to take care of clients. Your supervisor will direct you to perform tasks during your shift. See the Task Details section below for more information about common tasks.

- Welcome clients
- Support collection of client registration information
- Guide clients to their cots
- Direct clients to locations in shelter
- Talk with clients
- Provide information about Red Cross services
- Assess client and refer them to Red Cross services
- Help serve meals and prepare snack table
- Practice and ensure COVID19 safety requirements are followed
- Provide information about community resources
- Support data entry of client information
- Clean the shelter
- Receive delivery of supplies

TASK DETAILS

Task	Task Detail	Tips and Expectations
Welcome clients --- **Support client registration** --- **Assess clients and refer them to Red Cross services**	• Smile and be friendly • Provide the “welcome letter” • Be comfortable communicating and interacting with all clients • Identify immediate needs • Keep client information secure and confidential • Ensure accuracy when filling out a form on paper and/or electronically • Maintain confidentiality and sensitivity when having delicate conversations • Share what Red Cross services are available for referral, including Disaster Health Services, Disability Integration, Disaster Spiritual Care, and Disaster Mental Health	• Guide clients to their cots and point out locations of restrooms and feeding • Refer clients for other services using the method provided by your supervisor • Show patience, grace, and respect to all clients. Clients may show a wide range of emotions. Remember: They are stressed and worried about the impact of the disaster on their lives. • People affected by the disaster but not wanting shelter may seek services. Contact your supervisor for direction. • When in doubt, contact your supervisor.
Provide information about community resources	• Provide and/or post standardized community resource information fliers • Share information with clients on how to access information	• Inform clients of available resources that may help them in their recovery • Provide each client the same list of resources that have been verified by the Red Cross

Task	Task Detail	Tips and Expectations
Follow and support safety requirements	• Understand safety protocols • Communicate Red Cross rules for safety • Escalate concerns immediately to your supervisor • Monitor supply of face coverings and other items to issue to clients as needed, and inform supervisor when re-ordering is necessary	• Practice safety requirements • Remind clients to wear their face coverings and regularly wash their hands
Talk with clients	• As you move about the shelter, say hello to clients • Ask clients if they need anything; report needs to supervisor • If you have a few minutes, sit and talk with clients about general topics	• Be friendly and accessible • Help the clients feel comfortable in the shelter • Let them know you care about their well-being
Clean the shelter	• Pick up trash • Empty trash cans • Mop spilled liquids • Clean tables and surfaces with disinfectant wipes • Use disinfectant wipes on high-touch areas including doorknobs, elevator buttons • Pick up paper in restrooms	• Always wear appropriate PPE and follow directions on product packaging and from your supervisor
Provide information about Red Cross services	• Document questions received and answers provided • Understand basic range of services provided by Red Cross. If you do not know the answer to a question, call your supervisor. • Be familiar with current “talking points” • Direct clients and public to appropriate information sources • Work to calm tense and frustrated clients	• If you do not know if a service is available from the Red Cross, contact your supervisor
Help serve meals and prepare snack table	• Follow directions of the Feeding Supervisor • Serve or set out the amounts of foods directed • Serve anyone wanting meals including staff, partners working in the shelter, and first responders	• Wear mask, gloves, and hairnet or hat • Never touch food; use tongs, serving spoons or other utensils
Receive delivery of supplies	• Document deliveries received as directed • Notify supervisor when items are received • Maintain professionalism	• Store as directed in a secure space to receive • Keep all receipts and documentation and provide to your supervisor

CLIENT COMMUNICATION TIPS

Greet people 	Say hello, good morning, or whatever is appropriate for the time of day
Introduce yourself 	Take time to introduce yourself. Share a bit about your role. For example, "I'm Nigel. I'm here as a Shelter Worker to welcome you and help get you settled in."
Respond positively 	If someone has a request, say something like "I'm happy to help" rather than a simple "yes." When someone thanks you, say something like "I'm glad I could help" instead of "no problem." If you can't solve it, tell them you will take it to someone who can. Then do it.
Be careful with word choice 	Don't use slang or anything that is potentially offensive. If you interact with people with disabilities, use people-first language. This means putting the person before the disability. For example, you would refer to an individual as someone who uses a wheelchair, rather than as a wheelchair-bound man or woman.
Smile 	A smile is a universal display of friendliness and happiness. Smiles transcend all cultures and language barriers, and even when people are in troubled situations, a smile can help them feel better. So when you greet and interact with people, smile!
Make eye contact 	Make eye contact with people as you communicate with them. Also consider your body language.
Be yourself! 	Be friendly and natural. Tone of voice and gestures are important, but don't force a conversation or try to be more outgoing than you naturally are. Be yourself and engage with the other person in a way that puts you both at ease.
Be present in the conversation 	Listen to what each person is saying. Don't look at your phone or text/ email/ check Facebook while you're talking. Ask meaningful questions.
Personalize 	Personalize your interactions with people by using names. Ask questions that enable you to assist them or improve their experience. For example, you might ask if they received the information they needed or if you can help improve their stay in any way.
Show vs. give 	When people ask you how to find a location in our building, if at all possible, show them the way rather than giving directions. This can show that you want to help and are happy to take the time to be sure they get where they need to go with ease. It also gives you a chance to talk and discover any other questions they have or ways you can make their experience better.

Job Tool: "When to Refer to Disaster Mental Health" Reference Card

Disaster Cycle Services Job Tools
DCS JT Respond/Disaster Mental Health

The "When to Refer to Disaster Mental Health" Reference Card is a resource to help all disaster workers remember what to listen for when talking to clients and when to refer to Disaster Mental Health.

Psychological First Aid instructors and disaster leaders should use the following document to produce individual cards for all disaster workers.

Instructions for producing cards:

Option 1: Use local printing resource to have individual cards created as 2-sided business cards.

Option 2: Print using Red Cross printing resources.

1. Print the following two pages in color and 2-sided (on the same sheet of paper) preferably on card stock or heavy paper.
2. Cut sheets into individual cards.

Distribute one card to each disaster worker during in-person Psychological First Aid trainings or after taking the course via webinar or online.

When to Refer to DMH

American Red Cross

Refer to DMH NOW

- **In danger of harming self/other, CALL 911 NOW**
- Unable to care for self
- Severe emotional distress
- Confusion/disorientation

Refer to DMH ASAP

*Concerning **R**eactions*

- Unexpected reactions to stress
- Family/friends concerned about behavior

*Significant **R**isk Factors*

- Family, friend or pet killed
- Felt threat to life
- Witnessed death/injury
- Separated from family/caregiver
- Community destroyed

***R**esilience/Coping Ability*

- No family/community support
- No financial resources
- Lacks good coping skills

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- Unexpected reactions to stress
- Family/friends concerned about behavior

*Significant **R**isk Factors*

- Family, friend or pet killed
- Felt threat to life
- Witnessed death/injury
- Separated from family/caregiver
- Community destroyed

***R**esilience/Coping Ability*

- No family/community support
- No financial resources
- Lacks good coping skills

When to Refer to DMH

American Red Cross

Refer to DMH NOW

- **In danger of harming self/other, CALL 911 NOW**
- Unable to care for self
- Severe emotional distress
- Confusion/disorientation

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Refer to DMH By End of Shift

*Concerning **R**eactions*
- Difficulty thinking/concentrating
- Anxiety/nervousness
- Significant physical complaints

*Significant **R**isk Factors*
- Home destroyed
- Assisted with rescue/recovery
- Sheltered in place
- Has severe financial loss

***R**esilience Factors/Coping Ability*
- Some positive coping skills
- Some community/family support

Basic Psychological First Aid
- Take care of yourself
- Make a connection/listen
- Help people be safe
- Be kind, calm and compassionate
- Meet people's basic needs
- Give realistic reassurance
- Encourage good coping
- Help people connect
- Give accurate info
- Refer to DMH
- End conversation

127304 10/16

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When to Refer to DMH

American Red Cross

Refer to DMH NOW

- **In danger of harming self/other, CALL 911 NOW**
- Unable to care for self
- Severe emotional distress
- Confusion/disorientation

Refer to DMH ASAP

*Concerning **R**eactions*

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American Red Cross

Job Tool: When and How to Offer Disaster Mental Health Services to Clients and Responders

Disaster Cycle Services Job Tools
DCS JT Respond/Disaster Mental Health

Audience

This job tool is for disaster workers who work with disaster clients, including caseworkers, disaster action team members, shelter workers, and reunification workers.

Overview

The disaster worker is on the "front lines" of a relief operation and is often the first person to speak with those impacted by the disaster. The 3R's (reactions to the stress of the event, risk factors and an individual's resilience -- or lack of resilience) provide information that can help determine if a client would benefit from a referral to Disaster Mental Health workers. The 3R's help determine how well an individual will react and cope with the stressors of the disaster.

An individual who has unexpected reactions, more personal risk exposure, and/or difficulty coping should be referred to a Disaster Mental Health worker. Any time a disaster worker thinks that a person is having difficulty coping and needs referral, the worker should trust their intuition and refer this person. See the "When to Refer to DMH" Reference Card.**

When to Offer a Referral for Disaster Mental Health Services to a Client

Referral Needed **Immediately**

Workers should refer a client/worker <u>immediately</u> to Disaster Mental Health if he/she is:

- In danger of harming self/another – **call 911 NOW (before contacting Disaster Mental Health.)**
- Unable to care for her/himself
- In severe emotional distress
- Confused or disoriented

Contact a Disaster Mental Health worker immediately either by phone or in person when Possible. If a disaster mental health worker is not available, call 911.

Referral Needed <u>As Soon As Possible</u>

As individuals share their disaster stories listen for the following which indicate you should notify a Disaster Mental Health worker as soon as possible.

Concerning Reactions		Risk Factors**		Resilience
Family/friends concerned about behavior	And/ Or	Family, friend, pet killed	And/ Or	Has no family/community support
Unexpected reactions to stress		Felt threat to life		Has no financial resources
		Witnessed death/injury		
		Separated from family/caregiver		Lacks good coping skills
		Community destroyed		

Referral Needed By the End of the Shift

Many individuals would benefit from a referral to a Disaster Mental Health worker but the following risks are less urgent.

Concerning Reactions		Risk Factors		Resilience
Difficulty thinking/concentrating	And/ Or	Home destroyed	And/ Or	Appears to have some positive coping skills
Anxiety/nervousness		Assisted with rescue/recovery		
		Sheltered in place		Has some community/family support
Significant physical complaints		Has severe financial loss (business destroyed)		

"Taking Care of Yourself" Editable Wallet Card

Give each client the "Taking Care of Yourself" Wallet Card containing the national 24/7 Disaster Distress Helpline number as well as a local crisis number. Everyone goes through a different process of coping and adjusting to the stress of disaster. People may have a strong emotional reaction until in the middle of the night or at a time when they feel ashamed or embarrassed to tell friends or family that they need help. By providing the "Taking Care of Yourself" Wallet Card, you are making sure that each Red Cross disaster client has 24/7 access to confidential emotional support. See the Job Tool: "Taking Care of Yourself" Editable Wallet Card for more instructions about how to customize the card with local information.

How to Offer Disaster Mental Health Services to a Client

Some workers may feel uncomfortable offering a Disaster Mental Health referral to a client. Below are some tips and examples of language workers can use to discuss Disaster Mental Health with clients.

Tips for offering Disaster Mental Health support:

- **Avoid stigma:** If concerned about stigma, refer to Disaster Mental Health workers as "disaster counselors" or "stress counselors."
- **Keep things simple:** Simply ask the client if he/she would like to talk to someone who can help with coping strategies.
- **Don't judge:** A client may benefit from having someone to talk to after experiencing a traumatic or highly stressful event.
- **Ask about others:** Sometimes people are more comfortable requesting help for a loved one they are concerned about than for themselves.
- **Focus on Children:** Offer Disaster Mental Health services to parents who are concerned about whether their child is coping and adjusting well after a disaster.

Examples of what to say:

- "The Red Cross has disaster counselors who talk with people who have experienced a fire [or hurricane, flood, or other disaster]. Would you like a call from a disaster counselor?"
- "Red Cross counselors are trained to help people manage the disaster stress including helping you manage the challenges you are facing right now and what your family can expect down the road."

- "Children have different reactions to disasters than adults. The Red Cross has counselors you can talk to if you are worried about your children or just want to know what behaviors to keep an eye out for. Would you like to be contacted by a Red Cross counselor?"
- "You mentioned you (or your wife/child/father) have been treated for a mental health condition in the past. The Red Cross has disaster counselors who can help you (or he/she) identify strategies for coping with the extreme stress you (or he/she) are experiencing. Would you (or he/she) like to talk to a Red Cross counselor?"

When to Offer a Referral for Disaster Mental Health Services to a Worker

Disaster Mental Health Services also supports Red Cross Disaster employees and volunteers. Workers should consider requesting Disaster Mental Health Services for themselves or coworkers during or after an especially disturbing assignment. Some examples may include when a worker:

Concerning Reactions		Risk Factors		Resilience
Continues to think about a specific incident/client/topic	And/ Or	Witnessed serious/fatal injuries	And/ Or	Displays negative/poor coping strategies
Difficulty sleeping		Witnessed massive destruction		
Conflicts with other volunteers/staff members		Destruction of own community		
		Felt life was in danger		
		Worked with exploitive or unappreciative clients		

How to Make a Referral to Disaster Mental Health

Referral Needed Immediately

When a Disaster Mental Health worker is physically present

- When a Disaster Mental Health worker is physically present to support a client at a disaster scene, a shelter or another service delivery location, make a referral directly to the Disaster Mental Health worker by talking to him/her in person. When possible, introduce the client to the Disaster Mental Health worker.

When a Disaster Mental Health worker is not present

- Call the on-call Disaster Mental Health worker (or the established Disaster Mental Health phone number when on a Disaster Response Operation) and hand the phone to the client to ensure the connection is made.

Referral Needed by the End of the Shift

Client

- Ask when would be a good time for a Red Cross counselor to follow up with them. Complete the referral is to document the request in CAS 2.0 to ensure the Disaster Mental Health team is aware of the client's need. See the Job Tool: Documenting Disaster Health Services and Disaster Mental Health Information in CAS 2.0 for more details.

- If documentation in CAS 2.0 is not an option, use your best judgment to connect the client to a Disaster Mental Health worker while maintaining the client's confidentiality.

Worker

- Talk with the worker and recommend that he/she contacts a Disaster Mental Health worker for assistance.
- If necessary, notify the Disaster Mental Health supervisor assigned to that site and report your concerns. Maintain the worker's confidentiality. Do not discuss your concerns with others.

"When to Refer to Disaster Spiritual Care" Wallet Card

Disaster Cycle Services Job Tools

Response / Disaster Spiritual Care

PURPOSE

The purpose of this resource is to help disaster workers be aware of what to listen for when talking to clients and when to refer clients and other disaster workers to Disaster Spiritual Care.

AUDIENCE

Required	Recommended
Disaster Health Services workforce	Division Disaster Executives
Disaster Mental Health workforce	Regional Disaster Officers
Disaster Action Team Members	
Red Cross Sheltering workforce	

INSTRUCTIONS

Disaster Spiritual Care, Disaster Mental Health, Disaster Health Services, and *Psychological First Aid* instructors use the following document to produce cards to hand out on all disasters. Disaster leaders may also print this tool to help their workforce know when to refer clients and fellow responders to Disaster Spiritual Care.

Cards can be professionally printed as 2-sided business cards or printed double-sided using Red Cross printers and cut into individual cards.

Distribute one card to each disaster worker during in-person training or on a disaster relief operation.

When to Refer to DSC

Clients may or may not be part of any faith, spiritual or religious community.

Refer to DSC

- Missing/deceased person/pet
- Hospitalized client or loved one
- Referral from Red Cross team or family
- Service or sacred ritual needed such as funeral or memorial

Refer to DSC (cont.)

- Client requests presence of own spiritual leader
- Client requests prayer or spiritual support from Red Cross
- Client requests replacement of lost religious article(s).

Client in danger of harming self/others, CALL 911 NOW and consult Disaster Mental Health.

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Risk Factors (Client or Staff)

- Felt threat to life
- Witnessed death/injury or civil unrest
- Separated from family or caregiver
- Community destroyed
- Assisted in rescue or recovery

Signs of Spiritual Distress

- Client asks "why me?"
- Where is God in this situation?
- What do I do next?
- Why did I survive?
- Client expresses guilt, anger, grief

Helpful Questions to Ask:

- How can we best support your spiritual needs?
- What helps you through difficult times?

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Working with Disaster Spiritual Care in Shelters (and Other Service Delivery Sites)

Disaster Cycle Services Job Tools

DCS JT Response/Disaster Spiritual Care

Purpose

This job tool supports Shelter Managers and other service delivery site managers and the Disaster Spiritual Care Headquarters Lead on a disaster operation in ensuring that appropriate and respectful disaster spiritual care support is provided to members of the community while maintaining impartiality and neutrality.

Audience

Operations managers, Sheltering Leads, Shelter Managers, shelter workers, the Disaster Spiritual Care Headquarters Lead, and Disaster Spiritual Care staff

Procedures

The Red Cross welcomes faith providers from the community to visit their own parishioners or anyone who requests to consult with them. Try to provide private spaces where people can pray or engage in other types of religious practices with their spiritual advisors.

- Red Cross Disaster Spiritual Care workers who are assigned to a disaster operation have been trained in interfaith work. They are available to provide basic spiritual care services to anyone, regardless of their spiritual or other background.
- Red Cross Disaster Spiritual Care workers are also liaisons to the community and can help connect residents with local faith providers of their choice.
- If a client is in need of a faith provider, check with the Disaster Spiritual Care Lead at Disaster Relief Operation (DRO) Headquarters. It is the Lead's job to maintain resource lists of community organizations of various denominations.
- A Disaster Spiritual Care responder should be assigned to every shelter, although that person may need to itinerate to more than one shelter. If another Disaster Spiritual Care worker would be helpful at a shelter or other service delivery site, please inform a supervisor so a request can be made for a Disaster Spiritual Care worker to be assigned.
- Local faith-based groups or providers may wish to visit with members of their communities. Local faith providers are always welcome to visit individual residents in the shelter.
- If a local group would like to hold religious services for shelter residents, it may do so in a location that will provide privacy and will also respect the needs of shelter residents who do not want to participate in the religious activity. A separate room in the facility or a screened-off space may be a suitable location.
- Some national faith-based partners may also provide services at Red Cross shelters or other service delivery sites. Please consult with the Disaster Spiritual Care Lead at Disaster Operation Headquarters to determine whether a group has been invited or approved to provide services in Red Cross disaster sites.